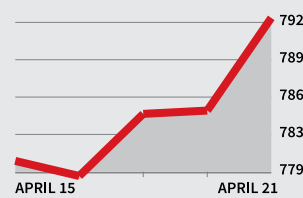


SENSEX 79273.33 (+753.03)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24576.60	+211.75
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.77	+0.21
US Dollar (in ₹)	93.50	+0.38
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	151745.00	+258
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	250513.00	-162

HOLY MACKEREL.

Seafood exports jumped over 15% in value to ₹72,325.82 crore and 13% in volume to 19.32 lakh tonnes in FY26 **p10**



POLLSCAPE.

Stampede a grim reminder as the AIADMK and the DMK fight for supremacy in Karur **p8**

QUICKLY.

MAJOR TRANSITION
Hardware chief Ternerus to take over Apple from Cook



Mumbai: Apple Inc has announced a major leadership transition, naming hardware chief John Ternerus as its next Chief Executive Officer, with current CEO Tim Cook set to become Executive Chairman effective September 1. The move, unanimously approved by the board, follows what the company described as a long-term succession plan. **p12**

Q4 SCORECARD
HCLTech profit rises 4.2% to ₹4,488 crore

New Delhi: HCLTech on Tuesday projected a revenue growth of 1-4 per cent for the current financial year (FY27) in constant currency and 1.5-4.5 per cent in services, compared to 2-5 per cent last year, citing market volatility across the world. The company posted a consolidated net income of ₹4,488 crore in the fourth quarter ended March 31, up 4.2 per cent on-year compared with ₹4,307 crore in Q4 FY25. Revenue grew 12.3 per cent on-year to ₹33,981 crore from ₹30,246 crore. **p2**

Amazon deepens AI push with \$25-b Anthropic bet

TECH DRIVE. As part of deal, Anthropic commits \$100 b in cloud spending for AWS over 10 years

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

At a time when Anthropic's Claude is gaining ground among enterprise users, Amazon has announced plans to invest around \$25 billion in the AI major.

The deal, which signals Amazon's aggressive push into AI, includes \$5 billion immediate investment in Anthropic with up to \$20 billion more tied to commercial milestones.

The \$5 billion takes Amazon's total investment in the AI company to \$13 billion.

EXPANDING CAPACITY

On its part, Anthropic is committing over \$100 billion over the next decade to AWS, and is securing up to 5GW of new capacity to train and run Claude.

This will mainly go toward securing access to current and future generations of Amazon's custom chips Graviton (a low-power CPU) and Trainium (an AI accelerator chip) to help Anthropic provide high performance.

It also includes an element of international inference in Asia and Europe for Claude



We continue delivering the technology and infrastructure our customers need to build with GenAI

ANDY JASSY,
CEO, Amazon



Our collaboration with Amazon will allow us to continue advancing artificial intelligence research

DARIO AMODEI,
CEO & Co-founder, Anthropic

to better serve its growing global customer base.

Additionally, AWS customers will now also be able to access the full Anthropic-native Claude console from within AWS through their existing accounts, with no additional credentials, contracts or billing relationships. Over one lakh customers already run Anthropic Claude models on AWS.

"Anthropic's commitment to run its large language models on AWS Trainium for the next decade reflects the

progress we've made together on custom silicon, as we continue delivering the technology and infrastructure our customers need to build with generative AI," Andy Jassy, CEO of Amazon, said. Amazon's stock climbed about 2.15 per cent to \$253.62 after the market opened on Tuesday.

"Our users tell us Claude is increasingly essential to how they work, and we need to build the infrastructure to keep pace with rapidly growing demand," Dario Amodei,

Gadkari pitches for flex fuel vehicles up to E100 to curb oil imports

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari on Tuesday pitched for accelerating the shift to 100 per cent flex-fuel vehicles (FFVs) in the backdrop of the ongoing West Asia conflict, saying vulnerabilities in oil supplies make it imperative for India to push energy self-reliance through higher ethanol use.

The crux of the government's evolving fuel strategy, sources said, is that E20 (20 per cent ethanol) will continue as the universal 'monofuel' available across the country, while higher ethanol blends such as E25, E27, E35, E85 and even E100, will be introduced as op-

tional fuels for compatible vehicles, giving consumers the choice to opt for cheaper blends depending on regional ethanol availability.

E100 VEHICLES

The government is parallely working on a fresh notification to facilitate rollout of E100-compatible FFVs, with officials indicating that the push for diversified ethanol blends had gained urgency amid geopolitical risks to crude supplies, even as the upcoming Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE-3) norms are expected to have minimal impact on electric and flex-fuel vehicles.

"In the near future, India should aspire to achieve 100 per cent ethanol blending... Today, we are facing an energy crisis due to West Asia



Nitin Gadkari

war, so it is necessary for us to become self-reliant in the energy sector," Gadkari said, addressing the Indian Federation of Green Energy's Green Transport Conclave.

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways had in December 2022 notified the applicability of test requirements for vehicles that can run on E5 to E85 fuel, a draft notification to replace the condition of E85 to "E85 or more" was issued on June 27, 2025. But the final notific-

ation could not be issued within the stipulated six months and the process lapsed, and within that period extensive debates started over the impact of ethanol blended fuel in vehicles and on mileage, including that vehicles required more maintenance.

The Centre had, in 2023, launched petrol blended with 20 per cent ethanol (E20) and currently, all vehicles can run on E20 petrol with minor changes to the engine to prevent corrosion and other issues.

FUEL MIX

Gadkari said India imports 87 per cent of its oil requirements, and therefore there is an urgent need for alternative fuel and biofuel.

Sources told *businessline*

that at a meeting of a working group on biofuel, held on Monday, it was proposed that fuel mix up to E100 should be made available across the country.

"E20 will remain as the monofuel, and other mixtures whether it is E25, E27, E35, E85 or E100, would be available as a choice to the customer. For instance, States where ethanol is available in abundance, they can provide the higher blend of fuel as an option to the customer, and where the ethanol production is limited, lower blend options can be made available. So, customers will have the choice to fill the fuel that is cheaper. But E20 will remain the monofuel across oil pumps in India," an official privy to the meeting told *businessline*.

For Gadchiroli Naxals, a move back to mainstream life

Lloyds Metals provides jobs, equity ownership and free healthcare to former militants

Suresh P Iyengar
Surjagarh

From toting guns while hiding in the dense forests of Etapalli to holding a demat account, Ramji Munshi Mattami's journey captures a striking transformation. Drawn into the Maoist fold as a teenager, he has since given up arms and is today rebuilding his life as a skilled worker and a breadwinner for his family.

Cut off from his family at just 17, Mattami said he could never have imagined a future when he would learn welding and earn a steady livelihood.

IMPULSIVE TURN

Mattami's story is part of a larger shift underway in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli — a district long known as a stronghold of the Communist Party of India (Maoist) due to its dense forests, poor connectivity and marginalised tribal communities.

His entry into insurgency, however, was almost impulsive. "When a group of people came to our village for recruitment, I was impressed by their bravery, attire and the guns they were carrying. Since our family was facing a lot of hardship, I thought of making money by joining them," he said.

The recruiters were reluctant to take him in because of his age, but Mattami insisted — jumping into their vehicle without knowing what lay ahead.

Mattami is among the more than 80 Naxals, including 31 women, who surrendered and are now employed by Lloyds Metals and Energy, which has emerged as an agent of change in the region.

The company has not only provided jobs — from welding to truck driving — but also extended equity ownership to workers completing six months, issuing shares at face value without



DRIVING TRANSFORMATION. Mining activity in the once Naxal dominated area of Surjagarh

a lock-in. Another surrendered Naxal, Kolu Majji Bhatpar, has no idea of the shares credited to his demat account but he knows that he has become a part-owner of the company.

Bhatpar, who hails from a small Bhamragarh village, decided to surrender after hearing of the struggles of his family members. "My children faced difficulty going to school and faced criticism in public. I walked to the police all alone and surrendered," he said.

Urmila Budhram from Gadchiroli has three children studying in an English-

medium school and feels happy to see her children daily. Her husband also works with Lloyds.

"A few years ago, no one dared walk the roads in this region, but things have changed a lot with the company now working in three shifts through the night," she added.

BPrabhakaran, Managing Director, Lloyds Metals and Energy, said the company was clear that the transformation of Gadchiroli would be possible only if people were provided with decent jobs, education and medical facilities.

"Getting talent for the school and the hospital was a big challenge initially, but today people are applying for jobs from big cities," he said.

The company has already invested ₹6,000 crore in Gadchiroli and committed another ₹25,000 crore in ongoing projects.

HOSPITAL FACILITY

The multi-speciality Lloyds Kali Ammal Memorial Hospital is the only hope for the under-served community.

The hospital is well-equipped with CT, MRI, digital X-ray, sonography, ECG, spirometry and audiology, besides five modular operation theatres, with separate ICUs for neonatal babies, paediatrics and adults. Gopal Roy, Senior Medical Superintendent, LKAMH, said the hospital will soon get a helicopter ambulance.

This correspondent was in Surjagarh on Lloyds Metals and Energy's invitation

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QUICKLY.

Amara Raja crosses 1 GWh lithium storage in telecom



Hyderabad: Amara Raja Energy & Mobility crossed one gigawatt-hour (GWh) cumulative lithium energy storage deployment in telecom across 50,000 sites nationwide with over 35 per cent cumulative market share as a battery player. “More importantly, it establishes a foundation for what comes next. The scale we have built within telecom, along with the systems, execution capability, and customer relationships, positions us to expand into adjacent segments such as data centres, industrial applications, and commercial infrastructure,” MM Venkata Krishna, Business Head – Industrial Batteries, ARE&M, said. **OUR BUREAU**

IKEA partners with Ekart for deliveries in Chennai



Chennai: Third Party Logistics firm Ekart announced a partnership with IKEA for the global home furnishing brand’s last-mile logistics in Chennai. Orders from Chennai, placed on IKEA’s website and app, will now be fulfilled by Ekart’s 100 per cent electric vehicle (EV) fleet. Chennai is the second major city where Ekart manages IKEA’s deliveries, following the partnership’s launch in Delhi-NCR in 2025. Ekart will enable deliveries within a 48-hour window with real-time tracking. **OUR BUREAU**

HCLTech lowers FY27 guidance to 1-4%

QUARTERLY PROFIT. IT major’s Q4 FY26 consolidated net income stood at ₹4,488 crore, up 4.2% year-on-year

Our Bureau
New Delhi

HCLTech on Tuesday projected a revenue growth of 1-4 per cent for the current financial year (FY27) in constant currency and 1.5-4.5 per cent in services, compared to 2 to 5 per cent last year, citing market volatilities across the world.

“Our guidance definitely is lower than what we started last year with. Last year was 2-5 per cent, this year it is 1-4 and 1.5-4.5 in services... Apart from everything else, we have two clients specific situations... They have planned significant ramp down and that itself had half a per cent decline. And, that’s possibly an additional element to consider when you look at the overall guidance,” C Vijayakumar, Chief Executive Officer and Managing Director, HCLTech, said at a conference call after announcing the Q4 FY26 and full-year results.

He said different categories will all add up to eventually drive the overall revenue categorisation, led by traditional services and amplification of artificial intelligence (AI) in data, cloud, cybersecurity and modernisation.

MAINTAINING RUN RATE “While the traditional services would decline, but our total contract value (TCV) is also the same as last year... In spite of the deflation.. we have maintained the same total TCV (like last year), which means we’ve been able to offset the deflation, and we have been able to win more, to maintain the run rate. So that is going to create some growth,” he added.

The company posted a consolidated net income of ₹4,488 crore in Q4 ended March 31, up 4.2 per cent on-year as compared with ₹4,307 crore in Q4 FY25.



Q4 performance (₹ cr)			
	Q4 FY25	Q4 FY26	% change
Net profit	4,307	4,488	4.2
Revenue	30,246	33,981	12.3
EBITDA	6,482	6,712	3.5

Consolidated revenue of the IT major grew by 12.3 per cent on-year to ₹33,981 crore for the quarter in review, against ₹30,246 crore in the corresponding period last financial year.

AI PIVOT “As the global economy pivots to the AI era, we are

evolving our all-weather portfolio and empowering our people so that we are nimble in adapting to fast-changing technology cycles and creating value for our stakeholders. We continue to invest in creating AI propositions that are well-positioned to leverage emerging long-term growth opportu-

ities,” Roshni Nadar Malhotra, Chairperson, HCLTech, said.

YEARLY NUMBERS For the full year, the firm reported a net profit of ₹16,642 crore, reflecting a 4.30 per cent decline from ₹17,390 crore in FY25, impacted by a one-off ₹956 crore charge related to the new labour codes. However, consolidated revenue in FY26 grew by 11.1 per cent on-year to ₹1,30,144 crore as compared with ₹1,17,055 crore in FY25. Meanwhile, the board of directors declared an interim dividend of ₹24 per equity share of ₹2 each of the company for FY2026-27. The record date for the payment of the aforesaid interim dividend will be April 25, and the payment date of the interim dividend will be May 5. Shares of HCLTech closed at ₹1,441.55 apiece on the BSE on Tuesday, up 0.92 per cent from the previous close.

AB InBev now a party under CCI lens

Reuters
New Delhi

The Competition Commission has made Anheuser-Busch InBev a target of a cartel investigation after the world’s leading brewer co-operated for four years as a witness, leading to a court battle in which AB InBev has obtained a temporary injunction, according to two sources and documents.

Since 2022, the Competition Commission of India (CCI) has been investigating 42 alcohol retailers in Telangana, the largest beer consuming State, for allegedly forming a cartel to exclude AB InBev’s rivals, leading to a surge in market share for the



Belgium-based maker of beers including Budweiser and Corona.

As part of the case, AB InBev was raided in 2024, but no other details have been previously made public in line with CCI’s rules on its investigation of alleged cartels. AB InBev’s status in the

case was changed from a third-party to “party under investigation” in November 2025, which was illegal as “no prior notice, hearing, or reasoned order preceded this drastic alteration”, the company said in a court filing that was reviewed by *Reuters*.

COURT HEARING

In a brief court hearing on April 16, a judge in Karnataka put the investigation against AB InBev on hold, two sources with direct knowledge of the decision told *Reuters*. The court order has not yet been made public, but one of the sources said the court took the decision as it saw merit in AB InBev’s concerns.

AB InBev, the world’s largest brewer, did not respond to *Reuters* requests for comment. Nor did the CCI. The sources declined to be named as the case details were confidential.

Making a company a party under investigation from a third-party is a significant change in any case and is done when investigators feel they have discovered some evidence against an entity, according to lawyers familiar with the process.

“Your rights of defence are compromised. Now the company needs to defend itself,” said Aavantika Kakkar, Head of Competition Practice, at law firm Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, which is not involved in the case.

Cyient DLM Q4 profit falls 28% to ₹22 crore

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Electronic manufacturing services (EMS) firm Cyient DLM on Tuesday reported 27.7 per cent decline in consolidated net profit at ₹22.44 crore for the March quarter of FY26.

Profit in the year-ago period was ₹31 crore. Revenue from operations stood 13.8 per cent lower at ₹369.07 crore in Q4 FY26, as compared to ₹428.05 crore a year ago.

On a quarter-on-quarter basis, profit and revenue rose 99.8 per cent and 21.7 per cent, respectively.

Ex-MRPL MD-led team probing Barmer refinery fire

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The Oil Ministry has set up a four-member team to investigate the fire incident in the crude distillation unit (CDU) section of the HPCL Rajasthan Refinery (HRRL) in Barmer, Rajasthan. However, all the units are structurally safe and unaffected.

The team, led by the former Managing Director of the Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals (MRPL) M Venkatesh, has reached the refinery and has commenced the probe.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas (MoPNG), said on Tuesday that the team has arrived in Barmer and have started the investigation: “Delays, if any, in the commissioning timelines will only be known after the investigation is completed.”



WHAT CAUSED THE BLAZE. *Prima facie*, it appears the leakage of hydrocarbons through one of the valves/flanges in the heat exchanger circuit caused the fire **PTI**

Prime Minister Narendra Modi was scheduled to inaugurate the refinery on April 21. However, the inauguration has been postponed and a new date will be decided later.

PROJECT COST

State-run Hindustan Petroleum Corporation (HPCL) holds 74 per cent stake in

HRRL, while Rajasthan government holds 26 per cent in the complex, which has a 9 million tonnes per annum (mtpa) crude refining capacity, including 2.4 mtpa of petrochemicals. The total project cost is around ₹72,900 crore.

HPCL on Tuesday said that the unfortunate fire incident occurred on April 20

‘Delays, if any, in the commissioning timelines will only be known after the investigation concludes’

in the CDU section of the refinery. *Prima facie*, it appears that leakage of hydrocarbons through one of the valves and/or flanges in the heat exchanger circuit caused the fire. “The fire was localised in the heat exchangers stack. The CDU, vacuum distillation unit (VDU) and all other units of the CDU section were quickly isolated. All units are structurally safe and unaffected. No other section of the refinery has suffered any impact,” it said.

An investigation has been initiated to ascertain the

cause of the incident and to undertake necessary remedial measures. The financial and operational impact, if any, is being assessed, and *prima facie*, is not expected to be material, the oil marketing company said.

Sumit Ritolia, Kpler’s Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modeling, explained that it is important to recognise that commissioning large, complex refineries is a phased process, and these incidents do happen. Moving from CDU startup to stable production of refined products typically takes a few months, with full ramp-up taking significantly longer.

“From a supply standpoint, the fire does not alter India’s near-term product availability. The refinery was not yet contributing to the product pool, and output had only been expected from Q3 2026 onwards,” he added.

EQT raises \$15.6 b in Asia buyout fund

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Swedish private equity firm EQT closed one of the largest Asia-focused buyout funds to date, with its BPEA IX vehicle raising \$15.6 billion in total commitments, including \$14.9 billion in fee-generating assets under management.

The fund, which was oversubscribed, comes when fundraising across Asia has slowed sharply

The fund is already 5-10 per cent deployed, including signed and announced transactions. The strong close underscores continued investor appetite for scaled platforms with a proven track record, particularly as capital consolidates among a handful of large global managers.

BPEA IX will focus on control investments in high-conviction sectors such as technology, healthcare, industrial technology and services, targeting companies



AMIDST A SLOWDOWN The fund, which was oversubscribed, comes when fundraising across Asia has slowed sharply

with resilient fundamentals and long-term growth potential including signed and announced transactions.

The fund is already 5-10 per cent deployed, including signed and announced transactions. Investor participation was broad-based, with commitments coming from a globally diversified pool across the Americas, Europe, West Asia and Asia Pacific. Pension funds and sovereign wealth funds led allocations,

while the fund also drew more than 75 new investors, including over 45 from EQT’s wider platform.

KEY ASIAN MARKETS

“In a highly competitive and selective fundraising market, our ability to deliver consistent realisations was a differentiator for our investors,” said Jean Eric Salata, Chairperson of EQT Asia.

The fundraise builds on EQT’s integration with Baring Private Equity Asia in 2022, which significantly expanded its footprint in the region. The firm has since deepened its presence in key Asian markets and broadened investment across large-cap, mid-market and growth strategies.

In India, EQT manages over \$8 billion in assets across companies such as HDFC Credila, Indira IVF, Sagility and CitiusTech, alongside healthcare IT platforms such as GeBBS.

Tech Mahindra Q4 margins expected to grow 50-70 bps despite muted revenue

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Tech Mahindra’s EBIT margin is expected to increase 50-70 bps in the March quarter, led by cost optimisation and currency tailwinds, as per brokerages.

Motilal Oswal Financial Services estimated EBIT margin to expand around 50 bps sequentially to around 13.6 per cent, while Choice Institutional Equities estim-

ates 70 bps increase, led by the Project Fortius cost efficiency programme.

“Management remains confident of achieving its FY27 EBIT margin target of 15 per cent, supported mainly by gross margin expansion,” said Choice in its research note.

Kotak Institutional Equities estimated 60 bps EBIT expansion led by operating efficiencies and rupee depreciation.

However, it expects muted net profit growth due to \$25 million forex loss. Meanwhile, Nuvama Research estimated a lower margin growth of 30 bps but still nodded in favour of the 15 per cent margin guidance.

FLATTISH GROWTH

In terms of revenue, the company is expected to report flattish growth.

Axis Securities estimated a 3.5 per cent sequential revenue growth led by higher contribution from BFSI and manufacturing verticals.

Telecom and communication are expected to grow as well while hi-tech and auto remain volatile.

Brokerages unanimously expect a strong deal pipeline with a focus on avoiding large deals that dilute margins.

Analysts noted that management remains focused on converting large deals and expanding the high-value client base, which will support medium-term growth visibility.

Margin improvement is likely to remain on track under Project Fortius, although much of the near-term profitability recovery appears priced in at current valuations, said Choice Institutional Equities.

“We forecast net new deal wins of \$1.1 billion, flat sequentially and up 38 per cent annually. Orange deal signed is substantial. Deal momentum in other verticals is also strong,” said Kotak Institutional Equities.

Firms suggested investors focus on company outlook for FY27 like margin expectations, reinvestment to accelerate revenue growth as well as pointed to the details on the agentic AI approach of Tech Mahindra.

Profitability of recently won large deals, hedging strategy (Tech Mahindra reduced forward cover over past quarters), demand outlook in the communication and hi-tech verticals, AI-led deflation, client mix, were other points of focus for brokerages.

Tech Mahindra will announce its Q4 and FY26 annual results on Wednesday.

Drivn builds \$140 m war chest for e-trucks, e-buses

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Gurugram-based electric mobility startup Drivn, founded by Manav Bansal and Alpna Jain, a former NITI Aayog executive, has built a \$140 million capital pool, including an \$80 million investment from Nomura in February 2026, and signed up around 300 electric buses and trucks as it targets India’s capital-intensive heavy commercial EV segment.

Unlike passenger EVs, deployment in heavy vehicles is charging-led, with use cases defined first and infrastructure built around them. Charging is planned route by route, with dedicated stations at points of origin such as warehouses and depots along high-utilisation freight corridors like Chennai-Bengaluru, Panipat-Kotputli, and the Gujarat-Madhya Pradesh belt.

For buses, Drivn has partnered with intercity op-



HEAVY DUTY. Unlike passenger EVs, deployment in heavy vehicles is charging-led, with use cases defined first and infrastructure built around them

erator LeafyBus to deploy electric fleets on routes such as Delhi-Amritsar and Delhi-Dehradun, supported by corridor-based charging. For trucks, the model relies on closed-loop systems at factories and logistics hubs. The company works with multiple OEMs, including Ashok Leyland, Tata Motors, JBM and Volvo-Eicher, positioning itself as an aggregator.

From the outset, the

Nestle India Q4 profit up 27% on robust volume rise

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Nestle India posted consolidated net profit of ₹1110.9 crore in the March quarter up 27.18 per cent over ₹873.46 crore a year ago. Consolidated revenue from operations grew 22.6 per cent to ₹6747.79 crore. Its board approved a final dividend of ₹5 per share for FY26.

Manish Tiwary, Chairman and Managing Director, said: “Nestlé India delivered high double-digit growth and recorded its highest-ever domestic sales at ₹6,445 crore. This was powered by double-digit volume growth, driven by over 50 per cent increase in ad spends.”

Total sales grew by 23.4 per cent and domestic sales grew by 23.1 per cent. “Encouragingly, all product groups contributed. Penetration and premiumisation, combined with disciplined resource allocation and strong execution, have been key... amidst the demanding external environment,” he added.

Tiwary noted, in FY26, the company remained focused on the fundamentals delivering double-digit, volume-led growth alongside strong market share gains. He added that over the last five years, power brands such as Maggi Noodles consistently maintained its leadership position, while Kitkat and Nescafe accelerated market share.

“We progressed on our structural cost-efficiency agenda and delivered highest-ever operational cost savings, which enabled higher reinvestments behind brands, accelerated digital, tech-enabled capabilities across sales and operations. We maintained tight discipline on profitability and cash generation and continued to upgrade and expand capacity



prudently to meet growing consumer and customer demand and support future growth. Technology was leveraged to eliminate costs that did not add value to customers,” he added.

While confectionery segment grew at high double-digits in both value and volume, the powdered and liquid beverages segment posted high double-digit growth. Prepared dishes and cooking aids posted strong volume-driven growth. “Milk and nutrition products showed resilience, delivering steady growth. Pet foods reported high double-digit growth,” Tiwary noted.

He added that Nestlé Professional emerged as one of the fastest-growing business delivering “sustained, penetration-led and volume-driven growth”.

RURAL SHOW

“In rural markets, we strengthened our route-to-market and accelerated reach expansion in a focused approach and delivered a strong scale-up in reach, supporting the highest reach increase among industry peers..., expanding our presence to about 216,000 villages and sharpening the focus from adding outlets to improving the effectiveness of coverage and execution quality,” Tiwary added. In e-commerce, growth momentum in FY26 was led by strong quick commerce. Organised trade channel delivered double-digit growth.

businessline.

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Govt proposes tweaks to IT rules for AI-generated content

VISUAL DISPLAY. Stricter disclosure norms to ensure ‘clear and continuous AI labels’

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Centre, on Tuesday, has proposed for stricter disclosure norms for content generated by artificial intelligence (AI), proposing tweaks to IT Rules that would require clear and continuous labels identifying synthetically generated information (SGI) to be visible throughout the entire duration of the visual display.

The amendment would replace the earlier requirement of ensuring “prominent visibility” of AI labels under the IT Rules.

Adding this to the draft IT Rules, among other changes, the government also proposes to bring independent news creators on its radar and mandate compliance with advisories.

The Ministry of Electron-



PUBLIC DOMAIN. MeitY has placed the additional amendments for consultation to provide stakeholders an opportunity to examine and submit feedback

ics and IT (MeitY) has extended the deadline for stakeholder feedback to May 7 from the once-already-extended timeline of April 29.

“In addition to the draft amendments already placed in the public domain, further

changes have been proposed in Rule 3(3)(a)(ii), which requires continuous and clearly visible display of label for synthetically generated information throughout the duration of the content in visual display,” MeitY said in

a notice. In another notice, it said the wording “ensures prominent visibility in the visual display” will be substituted with the language: “ensures continuous and clearly visible display of such label throughout the duration of the content, in a visual display”.

SUBMIT FEEDBACK

MeitY said that it was placing the additional amendments in the public domain for consultation in order to provide stakeholders an opportunity to examine and submit feedback on the additional changes, along with the earlier draft amendments.

The submissions will be held in fiduciary capacity and not be disclosed to anyone at any stage, enabling persons to submit feedback/comments freely without any hesitation, it added.

Trump threatens to bomb Iran if no deal by Wed

Press Trust of India
Washington

The US President Donald Trump, on Tuesday, said he would start bombing Iran if they do not agree to a deal with the US before the end of the two-week ceasefire on Wednesday.

“Well, I don’t want to do that,” Trump told CNBC’s “Squawk Box” when asked if he would extend the ceasefire with Iran to allow time for the peace talks to reach a deal to end the war.

“They have to negotiate. And, you know, the one thing I’ll say is this: Iran can get themselves on a very good footing. If they make a deal, they can make themselves into a strong nation again, a wonderful nation again,” he added. Trump said that if the cease-fire ends on Wednesday without an agreement, he is prepared to resume attacking Iran.

“I expect to be bombing because I think that’s a better attitude to go in with,” he said.

PEACE NEGOTIATIONS

Trump said he thinks the US is “going to end up with a great deal” with Iran to end the weeks-long war.

“I think they have no choice,” Trump said when asked about his expectations from the second round of peace negotiations with Iran.

“We’ve taken out their navy, we’ve taken out their air force, we’ve taken out their leaders,” Trump said.

“We’ve taken out their leaders, frankly, which does complicate things in one way, but these leaders are much more rational,” Trump said.

“It is regime change, no matter what you want to call it, which is not something I said I was going to do, but I’ve done it indirectly.” While the first round of US-Iran talks, held on April 11 and 12, ended without an agreement, uncertainty surrounds the second round.

Trump says he is considering currency swap with UAE

Press Trust of India
Washington

The US President Donald Trump has said that he’s considering the possibility of a currency swap with the UAE to help the West Asian ally

secure US dollars, as its oil-rich economy has been rattled by the Iran conflict.

In an interview, he expressed surprise that the nation needs assistance, but made clear he was open to the prospect of making the move to help meet his ally’s

concerns. “I’m surprised because they are really rich,” Trump said. He added, “Yeah, if I could help them, I would.” The UAE pegs its currency, the dirham, to the US dollar. It has an estimated \$2.5 trillion in savings and sovereign wealth funds.

India adds over 1 m PNG connections since March

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

There is a small silver lining to the ongoing West Asia conflict, considered the biggest energy-related disruption in history, as the war and acute scarcity of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) forced India to push aggressively towards piped natural gas (PNG), which has been gradually expanding but not at the pace expected.

For instance, India had around 1.67 crore domestic PNG (DPNG) connections as of February 2026, against a Minimum Work Programme Target of roughly 12.64 crore and a Pro-rata Target (PT) of almost 3.99 crore. The achievement is 42 per cent of the PT.

The crisis pushed the Oil

Ministry to cumulatively add more than 10.69 lakh PNG connections, including those that have been gasified. This is a record addition, with March alone locking in 6.1 lakh connections. Since March 15, on an average, more than 10,000 new PNG connections have been provided on a daily basis.

As the conflict impacted 60 per cent of India’s LPG imports, the government immediately prioritised providing household PNG connections in areas where pipeline infrastructure is in place with a focus on targeting nearly 30 lakh connections. There are a total of 60 lakh LPG connections near operating city gas distribution (CGD) networks that can easily migrate to PNG.

Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Petro-



leum & Natural Gas, said on Tuesday, “Since March, more than 5.01 lakh PNG connections have been gasified. Further, more than 5.68 lakh customers have been registered for new connections.” During March, over 3.25 lakh connections were gasified, and over 2.85 lakh connections were installed.

TARGETED MEASURES

The government has issued a series of targeted measures to manage disruptions in

LPG supply while strengthening the gas-based energy ecosystem.

A significant reform initiative linking the allocation of commercial LPG with the expansion of the CGD network in States has already begun to yield positive results, leading to accelerated infrastructure growth and improved last-mile connectivity.

The Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board launched the three-month-long National PNG Drive in January to accelerate the rollout of CGD infrastructure. It yielded significant results with CGD entities developing additional DPNG infrastructure for 6.5 lakh connections till March 31. Gas supply commenced for nearly 5.29 lakh domestic and 2,457 commercial consumers.



DELHI DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Government of India

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और सतत विकास की ओर

Many locations. Many gains. ONE NAME

01
Food Court
at Dwarka
(Annual Licence
Fee Basis)

10
Institutional
Plots
(Including
Religious
Plots)

21
Industrial
Plots

16
Commercial
Plots

01
Fuel Stations
(Annual Licence
Fee Basis)

24
Residential
Plots

01
Cafe Bamboo
Oasis, Baansera
(Annual Licence
Fee Basis)

05
Multilevel
Parking

01
Groups Housing
Plots

01
Janak Place
Shops
(Annual Licence
Fee Basis)

04
KIOSKS
(Monthly Licence
Fee Basis)

57
Commercial
Estate
(Built-up Shops)

DDA Announces Mega e-Auction

22nd Phase
Prime Residential, Industrial,
Institutional Group Housing Plots,
Commercial Plots...
and Many More

IMPORTANT DATES & EVENTS

23.04.2026 (Thursday) from 11:00 AM
Opening of Helpdesk, Starting and commencement of Registration

22.05.2026 (Friday) upto 06:00 PM
Closing Time of Registration & EMD Submission

The staggered details of auction will be decided after the last date of registration and the same will be published on the DDA's website as well as on the auction portal. The Applicants will also be informed through their registered e-mails.

For details about plots/properties and procedure, kindly visit our website and click the e-auction link available on www.dda.gov.in and download the same through “E-AUCTION OF PROPERTIES” link available at our home page.

Kindly note the digital signature of all the intending bidders are mandatory to participate in e-auction of DDA.

For further details regarding important dates and events and other clarifications regarding e-auction process you are requested to visit our website i.e. <https://dda.enivida.com>

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#3
India
NIRF
NIRF: Management Category: 2023, 2024, 2025 Hot tick of National Top-3

#53
Globally
QS
QS Online MBA Rankings 2026 (EPGP Kochi Campus)

#65
Globally
FT
FT Global MBA 2026 (PGP BL)

#69
Globally
FT
Financial Times Masters in Management Ranking 2025 (PGP)

#76
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FT
FT Executive Education 2025 RANKING OPEN ENROLMENT Financial Times Executive Education Open Ranking 2025 (MDP)

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#19 Worldwide
Value for Money: FT Global MBA 2026

#22 Worldwide
Alumni Network: FT Global MBA 2026

#26 Worldwide
Career Progress: FT Global MBA 2026

#48 Worldwide
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CM YK A CH-CHE

Railways’ performance

Claims on achievements must be seen in context

Sudhanshu Mani

Public narratives often derive their force not from outright falsehoods but from selective presentation. What is stated may be factually correct, yet the omission of context can render it misleading.

For example, it was recently declared in the Lok Sabha that Indian Railways (IR) has become the second-largest rail cargo carrier in the world, a milestone attributed largely to the near completion of the Dedicated Freight Corridors (DFCs), now spanning over 2,800 km and handling nearly 350 trains daily.

According to official logistics data for 2024-25, the top three rail cargo carriers by volume (in billion metric tonne) are China at about 4.1, India at 1.62, and the US at 1.53. The claim, therefore, while technically accurate, conceals important context.

FREIGHT TRAFFIC

The DFCs were described as “near complete” nearly two years ago. Since then, originating freight traffic (measured at starting point of loading, in million tonnes) on IR has grown by barely 3 per cent. Throughput, measured in net tonne kilometres, has remained almost flat, increasing by less than 1 per cent, while revenue growth has not kept pace even with the inflation putting a great strain of IR’s finances.

Moreover, while India may have overtaken US in originating volume, the picture changes when measured in net tonne kilometres, which is a better measure of revenue generation, where the US continues to lead by more than double due to longer haul distances.

A second claim relates to electrification. It has been stated that the shift to electric traction has yielded savings of ₹6,000 crore, cited as evidence of the success of the electrification drive and the benefits of investment in clean energy. IR is close to electrifying its entire network.

No comparable network has invested so extensively, with electrification levels as percentage of total network ranging between 40 and 80 in countries such as Germany, France, the UK, China, South Korea, Japan and South Africa, and below 10 per cent in large systems such as the US, Brazil, Australia and Indonesia.

This outcome was largely inevitable given the policy push and is also commendable at one level, particularly for reducing



FREIGHT TRAFFIC. Tepid growth over the last two years

dependence on fossil fuels, which has become even more critical in today’s war scenario.

Yet, the development raises questions. Has the pace of electrification exceeded operational need, leaving nearly 5,000 diesel locomotives, valued at about ₹30,000 crore, underutilised? Would it have been more effective, from an environmental perspective, to prioritise electrification of more polluting road freight instead of a mode that is already far more environment-friendly? Is electrification entirely green when more than half of India’s electricity still comes from coal?

These questions may seem like *a fait accompli*. It is reasonable, however, to expect that such investments would lead to IR’s energy bill to stabilise, if not reduce, with the decreasing dependence on volatile crude prices. Does the figure of ₹6,000 crore represent annual savings or cumulative savings over time?

With the current annual energy bill at about ₹33,000 crore (electrical energy and diesel oil combined), is it being suggested that without electrification it would have been closer to ₹39,000 crore?

The energy bill has in fact increased, rising from about ₹30,000 crore in 2018-19 to current levels, albeit a marginal rise. In the context of modest freight growth and passenger traffic that has yet to equal the pre-Covid levels, even this limited rise in energy costs raises questions about returns on investment. Moreover, with only modest increases in electricity tariffs, aided partly by procurement strategies such as open access, one might have expected the overall bill to decline with electrification.

At a fundamental level, these claims call for clearer explanation.

The writer is Retd GM of ICF, Independent Consultant and leader of Vande Bharat project

THE WIDER ANGLE.



PARAN BALAKRISHNAN

It was one of last year’s biggest diplomatic mysteries. Why did US President Donald Trump invite Pakistan’s Field Marshal Asim Munir for lunch at the White House and hail him as “my favourite general”? Was it only because Pakistan had lavishly praised Trump and declared he should be nominated for the Nobel Peace Prize, or were there other factors at play in that diplomatic reset?

What’s clear is Pakistan hasn’t looked back since that White House lunch. It’s now startled the world by emerging as the key intermediary between Iran and the US. When the first round of talks fell through, Pakistan’s top leaders worked the phones and criss-crossed the Gulf in their military jets. Munir kept up communications with Washington and spent three days in Iran. India may have scoffed initially, but few would have predicted US Vice President JD Vance would travel to Islamabad for talks, underlining Pakistan’s unexpected role as a facilitator.

Another figure who has been keeping a lower profile helps illustrate a different dimension of this evolving relationship. Bilal bin Saqib is Pakistan’s crypto czar. Formerly the prime minister’s special crypto and blockchain assistant and CEO of the Pakistan Crypto Council, he’s been closely linked with efforts to formalise the sector. Significantly, the State Bank of Pakistan has now allowed banks to open accounts for crypto firms registered with the Pakistan Virtual Asset Regulatory Authority (PVARA), signalling regulatory acceptance.

These developments dovetail with an earlier visit that attracted limited attention. In January, Zach Witkoff, CEO of World Liberty Financial, travelled to Pakistan and met Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Munir. The visit resulted in a non-binding letter of intent to explore the use of stablecoins, a type of cryptocurrency, for remittances and to develop a digital payments system.

Why is Zach Witkoff’s visit important? Witkoff is the son of Steve Witkoff, one of Trump’s key negotiators. World Liberty Financial is also majority-owned by the Trump family.

Saqib has been doing the rounds in the US, particularly in Washington, for



VIA REUTERS

Pak’s peculiar comeback on the global stage

From White House lunch to Iran talks, Islamabad’s dubious rise is being powered by diplomacy, crypto and connections

over a year. He secured a meeting with Trump’s top crypto advisor, Bo Hines, last June and participated in a major Bitcoin conference in Las Vegas. Among the prominent attendees were Donald Trump Jr., Eric Trump, Vance and Vivek Ramaswamy, who briefly ran for president in 2024.

During his US travels, Saqib is understood to have met Zach Witkoff and convinced him Pakistan offered significant growth prospects. On a later New York visit, he also met Cantor Fitzgerald CEO Brandon Lutnick, who, importantly, is son of US Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick. These links point to a broader effort to position Pakistan within global financial networks.

Pakistan is building closer ties with Gulf investors, especially in the UAE and Saudi Arabia, where Trump-family ventures already have deep ties

TRUMP-LINKED VENTURE

It’s also important to note that World Liberty Financial is embedded in a network of billionaires and large global funds. For a Trump-linked venture like World Liberty Financial, Pakistan offers the possibility of first-mover advantage in payments, exchanges and digital finance infrastructure. Shortly before Trump’s White House entry, it sold around half its equity for \$500 million to a group that included an Abu Dhabi prince. This sparked controversy because, soon afterwards, the UAE clinched a US agreement for access to advanced AI chips. Still, despite its influential backers, the company has had a difficult year, with valuations falling, mirroring a slump in crypto values.

Some analysts predict Pakistan may now move beyond its traditionally Indo-centric strategic outlook and focus more on the Gulf region. Pakistan is building closer ties with Gulf investors, especially in the UAE and Saudi Arabia, where Trump-family ventures already have deep ties. Pakistani analysts argue the country has already gained new clout

and will enjoy a higher standing in global affairs. As analyst Muhammad Amir Rana puts it: “Pakistan has found a sense of relevance in the regional and global political order that it has long been seeking.” Saqib is clearly not the only reason for improved relations between Pakistan and the US. Ever since the Russian invasion of Afghanistan, Pakistan has perfected the game of giving to the Americans with one hand even as they cause trouble with the other. With Pakistani assistance, the US was able to capture Mohammad Sharifullah, accused of involvement in the Kabul airport bombing that killed 13 US servicemen during the chaotic withdrawal from Afghanistan.

Taken together, these diplomatic, financial and security threads suggest Pakistan’s re-emergence on the global stage is not the result of a single initiative, but of a convergence of interests in which Islamabad has smartly aligned itself with Washington’s shifting priorities. Whether that position would endure beyond the Trump era is another question.

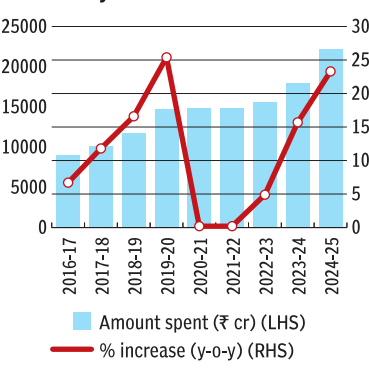
STATISTALK.

Compiled by Dhuraveil Gunasekaran | Graphic KS Gunasekar

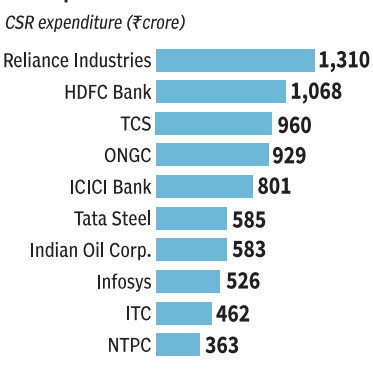
Corporate India’s CSR outlay hits record high in FY25

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) mandates that companies in India spend at least 2% of the average net profits earned over the previous three financial years on social initiatives. In FY25, CSR spending by NSE-listed companies rebounded strongly, rising 23% after several subdued years, according to primeinfobase.com. Large corporates continued to dominate overall contributions, shaping social investment outcomes disproportionately compared to smaller peers. While education and healthcare remained the largest beneficiaries, both saw a year-on-year decline in spending, even as allocations towards PM relief funds and rural development increased. CSR funding also remained geographically concentrated, with Maharashtra, Gujarat and Tamil Nadu together accounting for nearly 30% of total allocations.

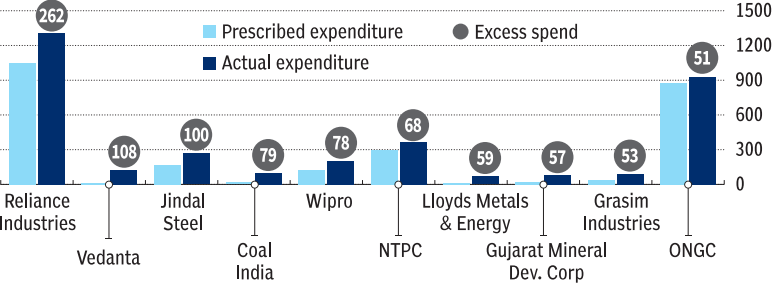
CSR spends rebound sharply after flat years



Top 10 companies in terms of CSR spends in FY 2024-25



Top 10 companies which exceeded their prescribed spending



Source: primeinfobase.com

Education and health lose share

Sector	Amount spent (₹ cr) in 2024-25	Increase over past year (₹ cr)	Increase (in %)
PM’s relief fund	122	90	4.5
Rural development	172	52	3.2
Sports	83	13	1.1
Reducing inequalities	76	9	0.9
Environmental sustainability	143	-6	0.7
Technology incubators	15	0	0.1
National heritage	27	-6	-0.1
Slum development	2	-2	-0.1
Armed force veterans	16	-7	-0.2
Disaster management	9	-15	-0.5
Education and vocation skills	862	-225	-3.8
Hunger, poverty and healthcare	528	-216	-5.5
Infra/ social welfare	26	-3	0.1
others	0	-1	0.0

thehindubusinessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

April 22, 2006

Turmoil in bullion market

Thursday’s sharp volatility in the international precious metals market and steep correction of prices downward has had its ripple effect on Indian commodity bourses. Prices of both gold and silver moved down in tandem even as the slide was swift and unexpected.

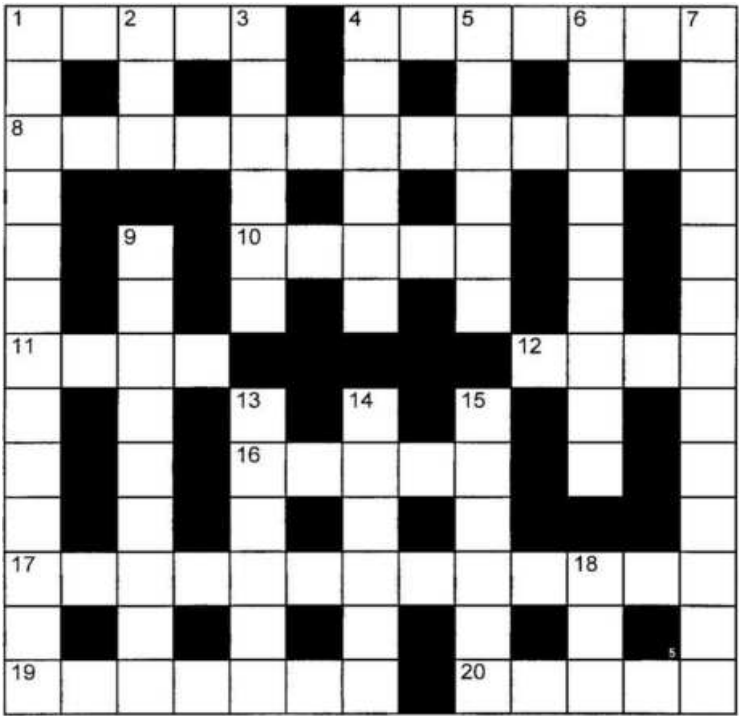
SUN TV issue price fixed at ₹875

The shares of Sun TV will be listed on Monday. The issue price for its recently concluded IPO has been fixed at ₹875. At 68,89,000 equity shares, the size of the fresh equity issue works out to ₹602.78 crore. Sources closely involved in the IPO exercise said the issue was oversubscribed 46.92 times.

Satyam Q4 net rises 38 pc at ₹284.65 cr; sets 1:1 bonus

Posting an all-round growth, Satyam Computers Ltd joined IT majors Infosys, TCS and Wipro in the billionaire league, logging software revenues of Rs 4,793 crore and net profit of 981.9 crore for the financial year 2005-06. The growth of 36.12 per cent in revenue and 38 per cent in net over fiscal 2004-05 also put the Hyderabad-based IT major amongst the fastest to cross the \$1-billion mark during the year. The company announced a bonus share of 1:1.

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2663



EASY

ACROSS

- Pointed (5)
- Clear coat (7)
- A questioning (13)
- Two times (5)
- Knot, swelling (4)
- Savage (4)
- Turn outwards (5)
- To start with; number one (3,5,5)
- Discussion group (7)
- Used broom (5)

DOWN

- Public pools (8,5)
- Human skill and agency (3)
- Freedom from defilement (6)
- A fiddle (6)
- Newspaper subscriber (6)
- With habit of copying (9)
- Twentieth part of ton (13)
- Breaking-up time (3-2-4)
- Pattern (6)
- Minor (6)
- Specifies (6)
- ‘Diamonds’ (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

- Last of players on Welsh instrument tuned above the pitch (5)
- Its application is clearly made to fade out right inside (7)
- Grilling or training toe to wriggle (13)
- Once and again, two have nice union on leaving (5)
- Knot that has been done wrong (4)
- Card having any desired value is so uncivilised (4)
- Turn out to be all-time teenage leader (5)
- Before anything else, it’s object number one (3,5,5)
- A group studying remains that are to be sorted out (7)
- Having been responsible for brushwork, Degas finally cried (5)

DOWN

- Where pools may be entered without putting pen to paper (8,5)
- Painting of Round Table monarch – top half only (3)
- Chaste quality turning up, it may be found in the railway (6)
- There’s nothing – nothing – four can turn up that’s bowed (6)
- Bookish person may be the one to correct the press (6)
- Copying one, you’ll find me getting it at four inside (9)
- Her hut-wedding somehow turned out to be a weighty affair (13)
- Why, where Hilary is concerned, the holidays follow it (3-2-4)
- Intend to make a pattern (6)
- Minor Saints one may look lecherous about (6)
- America, in short, sets forth (6)
- Finish making cake, none being cut if no impression is made (3)

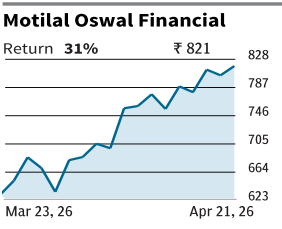
SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2662

ACROSS 1. Fused 4. Chateau 8. Architect 9. Red 10. Harness 12. Hear 14. Captain 17. Undo 18. Swollen 20. Tar 21. Spaghetti 23. Restore 24. Thong

DOWN 1. Feather duster 2. Secure 3. Driveway 4. Cue 5. Arts 6. Earned 7. Understanding 11. Sates 13. Ricochet 15. Adores 16. Blotto 19. Oslo 22. Ape

QUICKLY.

Motilal Oswal settles AIF breach case with ₹39 lakh



New Delhi: Motilal Oswal Alternative Investment Trust and its investment manager Motilal Oswal Asset Management Company and have settled a case with SEBI pertaining to alleged violations of alternative investment funds (AIF) norms after paying ₹38.76 lakh. They filed suo motu settlement applications with SEBI, proposing to settle the alleged violations by “neither admitting nor denying the findings of facts and conclusions of law”. The case related to Motilal Oswal AIF and the AMC arm facing regulatory concerns regarding their treatment of defaulting investors, distribution and servicing. **■**

Folks Motor registers
Folks Funds as Cat-2 AIF

Chennai: Folks Motor, a technology-led clean mobility company building next-generation xEV solutions, on Tuesday said it has registered Folks Funds with SEBI as a Category II Alternative Investment Fund (AIF). Folks Funds will adopt a sector-agnostic investment strategy, with a focus on high-growth opportunities across warehousing infrastructure, the electric vehicle ecosystem, data centres and real estate, the company said in a release. The fund will invest through a diversified mix of equity, debt, and convertible instruments, deploying capital via portfolio companies and special purpose vehicles. **OUR BUREAU**

ICICI Bank sees major ownership shift as FPIs, MFs trim stake

Our Bureau

Bengaluru

ICICI Bank has reported a significant shift in its ownership structure for the fiscal year ending March 2026, characterised by a reduction in direct holdings from foreign portfolio investors and major domestic institutions. The data highlights an evolving financial landscape where traditional equity stakes are being rebalanced across various investor categories as they manage their ₹-denominated portfolios. Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) recorded the most substantial movement over the twelve-month period, with their stake falling from 45.82 per cent in March 2025 to 34.48 per cent in March 2026. Domestic institutional players also showed a more cautious stance throughout the year. Mutual Funds, which held 29.86 per cent of the bank at the end of FY25, saw their share dip to 27.83

Raise Financial
buys algo-trading
platform Stratz

Press Trust of India

New Delhi

Raise Financial Services, which operates stock trading platform Dhan, on Tuesday said it has acquired algorithmic trading and investing platform Stratz in a cash-and-stock deal to strengthen its presence in the capital markets ecosystem. The financial details of the deal were not disclosed. The acquisition is aimed at expanding Raise Financial’s capabilities in algorithmic trading and offering curated, rule-based investment strategies to a wider set of users, the company said in a statement. Stratz, an exchange-registered algo-trading platform, offers over 100 approved multi-asset algorithms across equities, indices, futures and options and commodities. **■**

Nifty notches gains for third session; FMCG, realty lead

KEY TRIGGERS. Global sentiment, softer crude give strong start to Q4 earnings season

Anupama Ghosh

Mumbai

Benchmark indices closed higher for the third consecutive session on Tuesday, with the Nifty 50 gaining 211.75 points to settle at 24,576.60, while the Sensex advanced 753.03 points to close at 79,273.33.

The day’s gains came on the back of a broader cocktail — improving global sentiment around potential US-Iran peace negotiations, easing crude oil prices, and a strong start to the fourth-quarter earnings season.

SECTORAL RALLY

FMCG and realty led sectoral gains, each rising over 2 per cent, with private banks



BROADER STRENGTH. The Nifty Midcap 100 rose 0.49% and the Nifty Smallcap 100 gained 0.88%

and telecom adding approximately 1 per cent each. Nestle India, Hindustan Unilever, and Trent were the top Nifty gainers, while SBI Life, BEL and Dr Reddy’s ended as the top losers.

Sunny Agrawal, Head, Fundamental Research, SBI Securities, noted that the

earnings season had begun on a healthy note. “Companies such as ICICI Bank, Bank of Maharashtra, PNB Housing Finance, Nestle, etc. reporting strong set of results... most companies are either reporting in line or beating expectations.” The Nifty Midcap 100 rose

0.49 per cent and the Smallcap 100 gained 0.88 per cent. India VIX, the market’s fear gauge, dropped nearly 7 per cent to 17.53, a signal that near-term anxiety is unwinding. Shrikant Chouhan, Head of Equity Research at Kotak Securities, observed: “The short-term market texture is bullish, but due to temporary overbought conditions, some profit booking may occur at higher levels.”

WATCH OUT FOR

Looking ahead, markets will closely watch the outcome of the US-Iran talks in Islamabad, with the ceasefire deadline due on Wednesday. On the domestic front, the RBI’s MPC meeting minutes and the UK’s March 2026 CPI figures are also due.

PL Capital expects 4% Nifty earnings growth in FY26

Our Bureau

Mumbai

PL Capital expects Nifty to log an earnings growth to fall two percentage points in FY26 as country enters a challenging phase due to increasing geopolitical tensions, rise in crude oil prices and disruptions in the global supply chains.

The benchmark index will register a 4 per cent earnings growth in the financial year ended March 2026 against 6 per cent logged in FY25, according to the India Strategy report published by PL Capital.

The medium-term forecast suggests a compounded annual growth rate of 15 per cent for Nifty over fiscal years 26-28.

The Nifty is currently valued at 17 times its one-year forward earning multiple,

which amounts to a 12.4 per cent discount from its historical average of 19.4 times, which covers 15 years.

In the base case scenario, the valuation is assumed will be 17.5 times, 10 per cent discount from its historical average based on FY28 earnings per share of 1,551, leading to a target price of 27,080, it said.

The Nifty has fallen by 6.6 per cent over the last three months due to continued foreign institutional investor redemptions against the backdrop of geopolitical instability.

CHOPPY TRADE

Though there has been a significant rally after touching the lowest levels recently, market conditions remain choppy on the back of global risks and increasing commodity prices, it said.

The rise in the price of

crude oil will lead to higher costs in the import of oil by over \$70 billion annually, which may lead to inflation rising above 5 per cent.

Further, supply chain disruptions and the possibility of the El Nino effect on the monsoon season might lead to inflation becoming higher. GDP growth, currently at about 6.5 per cent, can further dip to 6 per cent.

Oil prices have seen a sharp spike and are unlikely to revert to pre-war levels. India, which imports 4.3 million barrels of crude per day valued at \$180 billion, could see its import bill rise by over \$70 billion annually.

Amish Aggarwal, Co-Head Institutional Equities, PL Capital, said near-term challenges related to inflation, interest rate concerns and foreign demand are likely to impact economic growth.

Citius TransNet InvIT IPO subscribed 20.43 times

Press Trust of India

New Delhi

The initial public offering of Citius TransNet Investment Trust received 20.43 times subscription on the closing day of bidding on Tuesday.

The ₹1,105-crore IPO of the InvIT (infrastructure investment trust) received bids for 1,25,40,24,900 units as against 6,13,88,850 units on offer, as per NSE data.

The category for institutional investors got subscribed 23.21 times, while the other investors’ portion received 17.09 times subscription.

Citius TransNet Investment Trust has mobilised

₹497.25 crore from anchor investors.

The price band for the offer is ₹99 to ₹100 per unit.

FUND DEPLOYMENT

Proceeds from the issue will be used for partial or full acquisition of securities of SRPL Roads Pvt Ltd and certain identified project special purpose vehicles, including Thrissur Expressway Ltd, Jorabat Shillong Expressway Ltd, Dhola Infra Projects Pvt Ltd and Dibang Infra Projects Pvt Ltd, as well as for general corporate purposes.

Axis Capital, Ambit and ICICI Securities are the book-running lead managers to the issue.

Family trusts can’t sponsor MFs, clarifies SEBI

Our Bureau

Mumbai

The capital markets regulator Securities and Exchange Board of India has clarified that family trusts cannot be sponsors of mutual funds.

Responding to a clarification sought by First Water Capital Advisory LLP through an informal guidance, SEBI said mutual fund regulations have made it clear that the sponsor should be a body corporate acting individually or in concert with another body corporate for establishing mutual funds or mutual fund lite.

Retail investors turn net sellers in FY26

Our Bureau

Mumbai

Amid heightened global uncertainty and choppy equity markets, individual investors reversed course in FY26, turning net sellers in the cash market segment after six consecutive years of inflows, according to the latest Market Pulse fiscal report by the NSE.

Net outflows by individual investors stood at ₹5,803 crore in FY26, a sharp swing from net inflows of ₹1.25 trillion recorded in the previous financial year.

“This reversal was driven by a combination of factors, including elevated market valuations that prompted profit booking, and bouts of

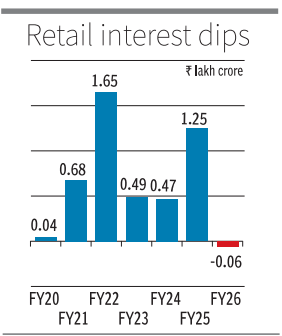
geopolitical uncertainty that dampened risk appetite,” the report said.

PROFIT BOOKING

The shift in retail behaviour comes against the backdrop of stretched valuations and intermittent global risk-off sentiment.

The report suggests that retail investors were cautious as they selectively reduced exposure in the secondary market even as broader participation remained intact.

In contrast to the pullback in the secondary market, retail appetite for primary issuances remained robust. Investments in the primary market rose to ₹42,608 crore in FY26, up from ₹34,336 crore in FY25.



“Overall fund mobilisation through equity and debt instruments reached ₹20.3 lakh crore in FY26, up 9 per cent year-on-year,” the report said.

PRIMARY MARKETS

IPO activity, in particular, remained strong with 219 companies raising ₹1.8 lakh

crore, the highest annual fund mobilisation on record.

The divergence between secondary market caution and primary market enthusiasm suggests that retail investors are becoming more selective rather than disengaged.

The NSE’s investor base expanded to 12.9 crore in FY26. However, the pace of new additions slowed. “New investor additions in FY26 totalled 1.6 crore, although the pace of additions moderated to an average of 13.5 lakh per month in FY26 versus 17.5 lakh last year,” the report said.

The exchange also said that the share of the top 10 States in total registrations has declined, indicating wider participation.

BROKER’S CALL.

Systematix

BANK OF MAHARASHTRA (BUY)

Target: ₹88
CMP: ₹80.16
Bank of Maharashtra reported Q4FY26 PAT of ₹2,010 crore, (12.3 per cent above our estimate of ₹1,790 crore) up 13.2 per cent quarter on quarter and 34.9 per cent year on year. The sequential improvement was driven by healthy net interest income (NII) growth, lower provisions. The bank reported a healthy sequential growth in net advances of 6.9 per cent in Q4 and 22 per cent year on year, while the deposits grew 9 per cent and 14.1 per cent correspondingly. The net interest margin (NIM) improved 5 bps sequentially (down 9 bps year on year). The yield on advances declined 20 bps quarter on quarter to 8.72 per cent. The management indicated that deposit repricing benefits are largely captured and have guided for a NIM of about 3.75 per cent, going forward. Gross slippages stood at ₹840 crore, while the annualised gross slippage ratio was 1.2 per cent. The recoveries and upgrades stood at ₹340 crore. This resulted in a net slippage addition of ₹500 crore. The slippages are expected to remain below 1 per cent levels, while the credit costs are expected to stabilise at 1 per cent, going forward. Further, the advances are expected to grow 18 per cent and deposits 14-15 per cent while maintaining CASA at about 50 per cent levels. Based on our revised estimates, we have revised our target price to ₹88 (from ₹80 earlier) and maintain our BUY rating on Bank of Maharashtra. We are valuing the standalone bank at 1.5x its FY28E adjusted book value per share of ₹58.

Anand Rathi Research

MASTEK (BUY)

Target: ₹2,240
CMP: ₹1,766.25
Notwithstanding macro and geopolitical headwinds, Mastek reported an in-line performance in Q4FY26, with CC revenue growing by 0.3 per cent q-o-q to \$103.5 million and a robust 13.6 per cent y-o-y growth in 12-million order backlog. As per the management, the company will see better growth in FY27 vs FY26, despite AI-led pricing pressure and macro uncertainty. The US saw sequential growth in order-book for the second quarter in a row. Margin declined about 70 bps q-o-q due to full-quarter impact of wage hike, partly mitigated by forex tailwinds and improved operational efficiency. Mastek added 27+ new AI-focused programmes in Q4, with the AI share of order-book rising from 3 per cent to 9 per cent over the last two quarters. Mastek is pivoting the commercial model from T&M to fixed-bid, outcome-based contracts. It guided about 16-16.5 per cent EBITDA margin for FY27 (vs earlier guidance of 16.5-17 per cent), implying no margin expansion. Strategically, the company is pivoting towards AI-led, outcome-based engagements, accepting near-term volatility for long-term growth and wallet share gain. Hence, we retain BUY on the stock with a TP of ₹2,240, which implies about 28 per cent upside from the CMP.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY’S PICK.

Welspun Living (₹132.40): BUY

Gurumurthy K

bl. research bureau

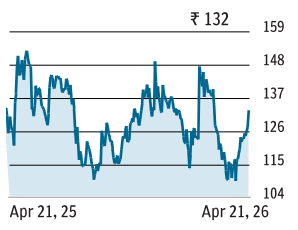
The short-term outlook is bullish for Welspun Living. The stock has been moving in a sideways range of ₹105-₹155 for more than a year now.

Within that, the share price is now moving up from the lower end of the range. The 4 per cent rise on Tuesday indicates that the upmove is gaining momentum.

Support is in the ₹130-₹125 region. Welspun Living share price can rise to ₹155, the upper end of the range in the coming weeks.

Traders can buy Welspun Living shares now at ₹132. Accumulate on dips at ₹128. Keep the stop-loss at ₹118

Welspun Living



initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹136 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹141. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹142 and ₹146 when the price touches ₹145 and ₹149 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹153.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24585 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
24490	24420	24630	24800	Take fresh longs only above 24630 with a stop-loss at 24590	
₹812 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
800	788	830	845	Take fresh longs above 830 with a stop-loss at 827	
₹1315 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1300	1290	1330	1365	Go long only above 1330. Keep the stop-loss at 1325	
₹310 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
308	306	314	318	Go long now and at 309. Stop-loss can be kept at 307	
₹283 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
282	280	285	288	Stuck in a narrow range. Avoid trading the stock now	
₹1355 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1340	1315	1375	1390	Wait for dips. Go long at 1345 with a stop-loss at 1335	
₹1110 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1095	1075	1115	1135	Take fresh longs above 1115. Keep the stop-loss at 1110	
₹2610 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2590	2560	2650	2685	Go long on dips at 2605 and 2595. Keep the stop-loss at 2585	
S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.					

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 211.75 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
HDFC Bank	811.75	54.42	15.77	11.03	
ICICI Bank	1388.40	50.22	17.16	8.81	
Hind Unilever	2310.70	15.33	54.00	1.82	
Nestle India	12379.90	14.63	81.58	0.98	
Axis Bank	1377.70	14.40	16.21	3.51	
Bajaj Finance	938.85	12.31	31.88	2.23	
ITC	309.65	9.78	18.74	2.65	
Eternal Ltd.	259.48	7.23	1084.01	1.66	
Trent Ltd.	4390.50	7.15	96.35	0.86	
TCS	2610.50	6.88	12.10	2.37	
L&T	4075.40	6.25	29.54	4.25	
Bharti Airtel	1855.00	5.96	30.51	5.05	
M&M	3247.30	5.01	23.89	2.58	
Kotak Bank	382.15	4.74	20.22	2.50	
State Bank	1111.85	3.62	11.86	4.10	
UltraTech Cement	12039.00	3.15	46.30	1.27	
Tata Consumer Product	1142.00	3.07	76.80	0.66	
HCL Tech	1441.20	2.97	23.74	1.35	
Asian Paints	2543.60	2.64	62.40	1.02	
Bajaj Finserv	1851.40	2.62	15.43	0.95	
Adani Ports	1594.10	2.53	29.39	1.04	
Hindalco	1021.65	2.02	14.28	1.31	
Apollo Hosp	7744.00	1.95	59.68	0.66	
Wipro	205.01	1.58	16.21	0.52	
Grasim Ind	2777.70	1.46	19.96	0.94	
Max Healthcare	1020.25	1.44	69.96	0.67	
HDFC Life	614.20	1.04	70.11	0.59	
JSW Steel	1279.60	1.04	40.29	1.06	
Hindustan Zinc	4693.10	0.74	56.51	0.94	
Coal India	445.15	0.69	9.18	2.20	
Tata Steel	212.01	0.52	29.01	1.56	
Infosys	1313.20	0.46	19.02	4.09	
Cipla	1232.50	0.37	21.96	0.62	
Maruti Suzuki	13461.00	0.31	28.34	1.57	
Tata Motors PV	355.90	0.09	48.40	0.66	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1407.80	0.05	21.32	1.30	
Eicher Motors	7240.50	-0.08	37.07	0.88	
Adani Enter	2226.00	-0.20	18.18	0.51	
ONGC	283.10	-0.21	7.92	0.98	
Bajaj Auto	9793.00	-0.24	30.81	0.96	
PowerGrid Corp	319.35	-0.35	19.13	1.28	
Tech Mahindra	1591.38	-0.40	32.03	0.85	
Sun Pharma	1655.20	-0.79	36.48	1.57	
Dr Reddys Lab	1220.60	-1.60	18.45	0.66	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	234.75	-1.72	95.55	0.68	
NTPC	396.20	-1.86	15.47	1.67	
Titan	4479.70	-3.00	83.45	1.64	
Bharat Elec	451.50	-4.73	55.35	1.44	
SBI Life	1911.61	-3.60	77.34	1.57	
Reliance Ind	1353.30	-14.74	18.73	8.11	
Nifty Next 50 Movers					▲ 483.45 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Varun Beverages .	485.10	71.67	53.58	2.65	
United Spirits .	1363.00	46.11	57.64	1.60	
Britannia Ind	5837.50	45.73	58.19	2.74	
Adani Power .	202.38	25.10	34.64	3.35	
Tata Motors Cv	442.55	24.48	98.96	3.69	
Cholamandalam&Fin	1589.20	24.06	27.93	2.71	</

QUICKLY.

IMGC, Bajaj Housing tie up for home loans

Mumbai: India Mortgage Guarantee Corporation (IMGC) has entered into a partnership with Bajaj Housing Finance Ltd (BHFL), whereby the latter will leverage IMGC's mortgage guarantee-backed solutions to expand access to home loans for the underserved and first-time homebuyers across India. IMGC's mortgage guarantee will also cover BHFL's Sambhav Loans, an affordable housing offering designed specifically for customers with informal income profiles or limited credit history, it said in a statement. **OUR BUREAU**

Karnataka Bank, Pine Labs tie up for PoS solutions

Mangaluru: Karnataka Bank has entered into a partnership with Pine Labs, a provider of point-of-sale (PoS) solutions. Through this partnership, the bank aims to strengthen digital payment options for its customers. Raghavendra S Bhat, Managing Director and CEO of Karnataka Bank, in a media statement, said: "This partnership aligns with our vision of becoming the 'Digital Bank of the Future'. Pine Labs offers user-friendly and reliable PoS solutions that play a vital role in today's digital payment ecosystem." **OUR BUREAU**

Second-round effects of West Asia conflict a real concern: RBI Governor

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Second-round effects of the conflict in West Asia are the real concern as what began as a supply shock can become embedded in the general price level, cautioned RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra. This statement comes in the backdrop of the global economy facing unprecedented challenges from heightened geopolitical tensions, the conflict in West Asia and disruptions to global supply chains. He observed that the appropriate monetary policy response to a supply shock is to look through the first-round effect to the extent that it does not feed into second-round dynamics. "Second-round effects are the real concern. They can materialise if the supply chain disruptions continue for long. Then, what began as a supply shock can become

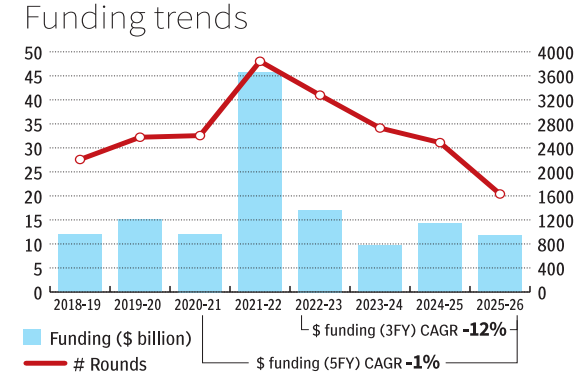
Start-up deals drop 34%, funding down only 18%

GROWTH SIGNALS. \$11.7 b raised in FY26; IPOs hit decade high

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

India's start-up ecosystem raised \$11.7 billion across 1,632 funding rounds in FY26, with investors making fewer but larger bets even as deal volume fell sharply, according to the Tracxn Geo Annual Report. Deal count dropped 34 per cent year-on-year, but total funding declined only 18 per cent from \$14.3 billion the prior year — a divergence that signals concentration rather than retreat. Median cheque sizes grew substantially as investors raised quality thresholds, particularly at the growth stage. Early-stage funding bucked the trend entirely, rising 33 per cent to \$4.8 billion despite fewer rounds, while late-stage fell 38 per cent.

HIGHEST COUNT Enterprise Applications (\$3.6 billion), FinTech (\$2.4 billion) and Retail (\$2.4 billion) led sectors. The year's three largest rounds — Nxttra at \$710 million, Neysa at \$600 million and Inox Clean Energy at \$344 million — pointed to growing investor appetite for founda-



tional infrastructure plays. India recorded 47 tech IPOs in FY26, up 52 per cent from 31 the prior year and the highest in a decade. Lenskart (\$7.9 billion market cap at listing), Groww (\$7 billion), Meesho (\$5.6 billion) and Physics Wallah (\$3.6 billion) were among the marquee debutants. Late-stage companies accounted for 44 per cent of equity-funded listings, up from 36 per cent the prior year. Six new unicorns — Neysa, Raise, Navi, Jumbotail, JSW One MSME and Juspay — brought India's cumulative tally to 125, the third-largest globally. The FY26 cohort reached billion-dollar valuations on

an average of \$150 million raised, roughly half the \$294 million required by the prior year's class. A survey of about 30 India-focused VCs found 74 per cent expect conditions to improve in 2026, with AI/ML and Deep Tech cited as top priorities by 71 per cent each.

₹ drops 38 paise on global cues

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The rupee extended its losing streak on Tuesday, declining about 38 paise, as ongoing geopolitical tensions, importer-driven dollar demand and partial roll back of the April 1 RBI measures that prevented authorised dealers from offering foreign exchange derivative contract weighed on it.

The rupee ended the day weaker at 93.51 per US dollar against the previous close of 93.13. "By allowing genuine hedging flows to resume, the RBI is restoring normal market function. But by keeping limits like the \$100-million cap on net open positions, it is ensuring that speculative excess does not creep back in. With more freedom for hedging, dollar demand is likely to increase in the near term. And that adds another layer of pressure on the rupee," Amit Papari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, said.

Near-term support ahead for rupee

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The rupee seems to be struggling for a sustained recovery. The rise from the low of 93.43 has failed to gather momentum. The domestic currency touched a high of 92.66 on Friday last week. But it has declined sharply in the past two days, giving away all the gains.

The rupee fell to a low of 93.63, before closing the day at 93.49 on Tuesday.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

The crude oil price jumping from around \$90 per barrel on Friday to about \$97 on Monday has dragged the rupee lower.

The Brent crude oil price has been stable at around \$95 so far this week. Oil prices have to drop below \$90 and continue to sustain lower. Only then can the rupee get some support for a sustained recovery.



A near-term support for the rupee is at 93.70, which could be tested this week. A break below it can drag the rupee lower to 94.10-94.20 in a week or two.

On the other hand, if the rupee manages to reverse higher from around 93.70, it could see some recovery. In that case, 92.70-92.60 can be seen again. For this to happen, Brent Crude oil prices will have to drop below \$90 in the coming days.

MIXED PICTURE

On the charts, the immediate outlook for Brent Crude Oil (\$95) is mixed. Support is around \$88 and resistance is at \$100. Broadly, prices can remain in the range of \$88-100 for some time now. A breakout on either side of

\$88-100 will then determine the next leg of move.

A break below \$88 can drag the price down to \$82. This could be positive for the rupee. But if the oil price moves above \$100, it can go up to \$105 and even \$110 again. That, in turn, will add more pressure to the domestic currency. We will have to wait and watch.

FRESH RISE

Barring the fall to 97.63 on Friday last week, the dollar index (98.20) has been broadly stable above 98. The price action indicates the absence of fresh sellers to drag the index lower. That leaves the bias positive. Resistance is around 98.65.

We expect the index to break this resistance and rise to 99.30-99.50 in the short term. Such a rise will also increase the chances of revisiting 100-100.50 on the upside eventually in the coming weeks. If the dollar index strengthens going forward, that could be negative for the rupee.

TATA POWER
Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India
(Board Line: 022-67173917) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567
NOTICE INVITING TENDER (NIT)
The Tata Power Company Limited invites tenders from eligible vendors for the following package (Two Part Bidding) in Transmission division, Mumbai.
• Supply and Services for Upgradation of SCADA Automation system at various locations of Transmission Receiving stations in Mumbai (Package Reference no.: CC27NP005).
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Interested bidders to submit Tender Fee and Authorization Letter upto **1500 hrs of 30th April 2026** for above tender. Also, all future corrigendum's (if any), to the above tender will be informed on Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

भारतीय रिज़र्व बैंक
RESERVE BANK OF INDIA
www.rbi.org.in
RECRUITMENT OF JUNIOR ENGINEER(CIVIL/ELECTRICAL) – 2026
Reserve Bank of India invites applications from eligible candidates for the post of Junior Engineer (Civil/Electrical) (11 posts) in various offices of the Bank. Selection for the post will be through a country-wide centre-wise competitive Online Examination and Language Proficiency Test. The full text of advertisement will be available on the Bank's website (www.rbi.org.in) in the third week of April 2026 and is also being published in Employment News/ Rozgar Samachar. Applications will be accepted only online through the Bank's website.
Important Dates:

Application Submission Window and Payment of Examination Fees Online	April 16, 2026 - May 06, 2026
Date of Online Examination (Tentative)	June 06, 2026

"Don't get cheated by E-mails/ SMSs/ Calls promising you money"

TELANGANA POWER GENERATION CORPORATION LIMITED
VIDYUT SOUDHA :: HYDERABAD – 82.
T.No.e-01/CE/Civil/Thermal/TGGENCO/2026-27
BTPS – Supply and erection of Furniture i.e Tables, Chairs, MS Filing cabinet, MS Industrial Lockers, MS Book Case, MS Slotted angle rack, & other etc., for establishment of School, at Bhadradi Thermal Power Station, Manuguru, Bhadradi Kothagudem Dist. Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **16.04.2026 at 17:00 Hrs.**
T.No.e-10/CE/Q&M/KTPS-VII/P31/EM/TGGENCO/2026-27
KTPS-VII – Supply, Erection, Commissioning of 6.6 KV vacuum Circuit Breakers of ICHP at Kothagudem Thermal Power Station Stage-VII, Paloncha, Bhadradi Kothagudem Dist. Value of the works: **Rs.36,00,000/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **10.04.2026 at 17:20 Hrs** 05.05.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
T.No.e-16/CE/Q&M/KTPS-VII/P31/EM/TGGENCO/2026-27
KTPS-VII – Procurement of 100 KVA, 415/415V LT Dry type Transformer at Kothagudem Thermal Power Station Stage-VII Stage, Paloncha, Bhadradi Kothagudem Dist. Value of the works: **Rs.15,90,000/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **15.04.2026 at 09:59 Hrs** 07.05.2026 at 15:30 Hrs.
T.No.e-378/CE/Q&M/KTPP/CAM-I/TGGENCO/2025-26
KTPP – Procurement of Anthracite, Grade Sand filter media and pebbles for Rapid Gravity Filters for water system at Kakatiya Thermal Power Project, Chelapur (V), Jayashankar Bhoopalapally Dist. Value of the works: **Rs.19,83,000/-** Scheduled Open & Closing Date: **18.04.2026 at 10:30 Hrs.** & **06.05.2026 at 10:30 Hrs.**
For further Details: www.tggenco.com & www.tender.telangana.gov.in
DIPR R.O.No.54-PP/CL-AGENCY/ADVT/2026-27, Dt: 21-04-2026

Muthoot Finance Ltd
Registered Office: Muthoot Finance Limited, NH Bypass, Palairavattom, Kochi - 682028, Kerala, India..
CIN: L65910KL1997PLC011300
Tel: 0484 2396478, 2394712; Fax : 0484 2396506, 2397399;
Website: www.muthootfinance.com, Email: cs@muthootgroup.com

COMMUNICATION TO SHAREHOLDERS REGARDING DEDUCTION OF TAX AT SOURCE ON DIVIDEND
The Board of Directors of Muthoot Finance Limited at their meeting held on April 10, 2026, has declared an interim dividend of Rs. 30/- per equity share for the financial year 2025-26. The Interim Dividend of Rs. 30/- per equity share will be paid to the shareholders on the basis of the details of beneficial ownership furnished by the Depositories and in respect of shares held in Physical form to those Members whose names will appear on the Register of Members of the Company as on the close of business hours on **Friday, April 17, 2026**.
In accordance with the provisions of the Income Tax Act, 2025, the Company would be required to apply withholding tax / deduct taxes at source (TDS) at the prescribed rates on the dividend paid to its shareholders. The withholding tax rate would vary depending on the residential status of the shareholder and the documents submitted by them and as acceptable to the Company.
Details in this regard, including requisite documents to be submitted for exemption from TDS for various categories of Shareholders, are available on the website of the Company at <https://www.muthootfinance.com/notice-to-investor>. You are requested to upload the documents with the Registrar and Transfer Agent (RTA) of the Company M/S MUFG Intime India Private Limited at <https://web.in.mpms.mufg.com/forms/regsubmission-of-form-15g-15h.html> or email to coimbatore@in.mpms.mufg.com latest by April 27, 2026.
No communication on tax determination shall be entertained after the said date.
Further details are available on:
(1) The Company's website: www.muthootfinance.com
(2) BSE Limited's website: www.bseindia.com
(3) National Stock Exchange of India Limited's website: www.nseindia.com
For Muthoot Finance Limited
Sd/-
Rajesh A
Company Secretary
Place : Kochi
Date : April 22, 2026

Sakthi Finance
Since 1955
SAKTHI FINANCE LIMITED
CIN : L65910T21955PLC000145
Regd.Office : 62, Dr.Nanjappa Road, Coimbatore - 641 018 Tel : (0422) 4236200;
Fax : (0422) 2231915 E-mail : investors@sakthifinance.com | Website : www.sakthifinance.com
NOTICE TO THE SHAREHOLDERS
SPECIAL WINDOW : RE-LODGEMENT FOR TRANSFER AND DEMATERIALISATION OF PHYSICAL SECURITIES
Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") had discontinued transfer of physical shares from 1 April 2019. However, a special window was opened by SEBI from 7 July 2025 to 6 January 2026 for re-lodgement of physical share transfer requests originally submitted before 1 April 2019 but returned due to deficiencies in documentation.
In order to facilitate the Investors, the SEBI has, by its Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/3750/2026 dated 30 January 2026, decided to open another special window for one year from 5 February 2026 to 4 February 2027. While lodging request under special window for transfer of physical shares, one of the mandatory requirements is submission of original share certificate which is as follows:

Execution date of transfer deed	Lodged for transfer before 1 April 2019	Original Security Certificate Available?	Eligible to lodge in the current window?
Before 1 April 2019	No (it is fresh lodgement)	Yes	✓
	Yes (It was rejected / returned earlier)	Yes	✓
	Yes	No	x
	No	No	x

Further, the following cases will not be considered under this window:
• Cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee.
• Securities which have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund ("IEPF").
NOTE : All shares re-lodged during this period will be processed through the transfer-cum-demat route i.e. they will only be issued in dematerialised ("demat") form after transfer and it will be subject to a lock-in for one year.
Shareholders who have missed the earlier deadline for re-lodgement of transfer deeds are once again encouraged to take advantage of this opportunity by providing the necessary documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("RTA"), MUFG Intime India Private Limited and in case of any clarification, shareholders concerned can get in touch with the Company/ RTA at any of the addresses given below:

Sakthi Finance Limited	MUFG Intime India Private Limited
No. 62, Dr. Nanjappa Road Coimbatore - 641 018 Tel : (0422) 4236200 Fax : (0422) 2231915 E-mail : investors@sakthifinance.com Website : https://sakthifinance.com/	"Surya", 35, Mayflower Avenue, Behind Senthil Nagar, Sowripalayam Road, Coimbatore - 641028 Tel : (0422) 2314792 / 4958995/ 2539835/36 Email : coimbatore@in.mpms.mufg.com Website: https://in.mpms.mufg.com/

Update of KYC and conversion of physical shares into dematerialised form:
Shareholders holding shares in physical form are encouraged to update their KYC details and convert their physical shares into demat form. Holding shares in dematerialised form offers multiple benefits and eliminates the risks associated with the physical share certificates.
COMMUNICATION FOR SECOND 100-DAY CAMPAIGN "SAKSHAM NIVESHAK" - ACTION REQUIRED FOR UNPAID/UNCLAIMED DIVIDENDS AND KYC UPDATES
In terms of Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority ("IEPFA"), Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") communication dated 27th March 2026, Sakthi Finance Limited is pleased to inform you of the commencement of Second 100-day special outreach initiative titled "Saksham Niveshak", starting from 1st April 2026 to 9th July 2026.
This campaign is being undertaken to facilitate shareholders in updating Know Your Customer ("KYC") details including:
• Bank account mandates
• Nominee Registration
• Contact information (e-mail, mobile number, address)
This campaign is also being undertaken to facilitate the shareholders to claim their Unpaid/Unclaimed Dividends for any financial year in order to prevent their dividend amount and shares being transferred to IEPFA.
Shareholder Action Required:
Further, we wish to inform you that in terms of the amendment made to the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations 2015, as amended, the provisions of Regulation 12 read with Schedule - I have been amended by omitting the provisions relating to issuance of 'Dividend Warrants' with effect from 18th November 2025.
Due to the above regulatory change, all future dividend payments shall be made only through electronic mode of payment approved by the Reserve Bank of India. The Company will not be paying dividend(s) through physical mode i.e., 'Dividend Warrants'. Shareholders who have not registered or updated their bank account details will not be able to receive dividends until such details are duly registered/updated.
In view of the above, shareholders are requested to :
1. Ensure that their bank account details are correctly registered/updated with the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (for physical shareholders) to enable electronic credit of dividend.
2. Update the email address and mobile number for timely receipt of dividend intimations and other electronic communications.
Note : Shareholders holding shares in physical form are requested to convert physical form to demat form at the earliest possible as it will be beneficial for market liquidity.
Shareholders who have not claimed their dividends or have incomplete KYC records are requested to contact the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("RTA") at MUFG Intime India Private Limited at the earliest. Additionally, shareholders are encouraged to register and track their requests through the SWAYAM portal : <https://swayam.in.mpms.mufg.com>.
Important Advisory:
Please note that as per applicable provisions, if dividends remain unclaimed for a period of seven consecutive years, the dividend amounts and corresponding base shares (if available) are liable to be transferred to IEPFA.
We urge all shareholders to take prompt action during the campaign period to safeguard their entitlement and ensure compliance with statutory requirements.
For Sakthi Finance Limited
S. Venkatesh
Company Secretary and Chief Compliance Officer
21 April 2026
Coimbatore - 18
FCS 7012

Paradeep Phosphates Limited
CIN: L20122OR1981PLC001020
Registered Office: 5th Floor, Orissa State Handloom Weavers' Co-Operative Building, Pandit J N Marg, Bhubaneswar – 751 001 Tel: 0674 666 6100, E-mail: cs.ppl@adventz.com.
Website: www.paradeepphosphates.com
NOTICE
SPECIAL WINDOW FOR TRANSFER AND DEMATERIALISATION (DEMAT) OF PHYSICAL SHARES
Kindly note that a Special Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation (Demat) of Physical Shares will remain open up to **February 04, 2027** as per SEBI Circular No. HO/38/13/11(2)2026-MIRSD-POD/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 ('SEBI Circular').
This facility is available to those investors who had purchased physical shares of Erstwhile **MANGALORE CHEMICALS & FERTILIZERS LIMITED** [now merged with Paradeep Phosphates Limited (Company) w.e.f. 16.10.2025] prior to April 01, 2019, and:
i. Had not lodged the shares for transfer; or
ii. Had lodged the shares for transfer, but the same were rejected, returned or not attended due to deficiencies in documentation.
For clarity regarding the applicability of this window for transfer deeds executed prior to April 01, 2019, investors may refer to the below matrix:

Lodged for transfer before April 01, 2019	Availability of the Original Share Certificate with the Investor	Eligibility under the Special Window
No (fresh lodgement)	Yes	✓ (subject to conditions stated under SEBI Circular)
Yes (rejected / returned earlier)	Yes	
Yes	No	x
No	No	x

Request(s) which are accompanied with original share certificate(s) along with transfer deed(s) and other supporting documents will only be considered under the Special Window.
Investors wishing to avail of this Special Window may contact the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent, as below:
MUFG Intime India Private Limited
(Formerly Link Intime India Private Limited)
Unit: Paradeep Phosphates Limited,
C-101, Embassy 247, L.B.S Marg, Vikhroli West, Mumbai – 400 083.
Email- investor.helpdesk@in.mpms.mufg.com
For further details, investors may refer to the SEBI Circular by scanning the QR code above.
for Paradeep Phosphates Limited
Sd/-
Sachin Patil
Company Secretary
Place : Bengaluru
Date : April 21, 2026

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Stampede a grim reminder as AIADMK and DMK fight for supremacy in Karur

MOVING AHEAD. While residents acknowledge the 2025 tragedy that claimed 40 lives, they downplay its electoral impact

T E Raja Simhan
Karur

Karur, located in the Cauvery delta belt, grabbed national headlines in September 2025 after the tragic stampede at actor-politician C Joseph Vijay’s rally claimed 40 lives. Months later, the scars remain, especially among older residents, even as the youth appear largely undeterred, continuing to back Vijay’s political foray.

TWO HEAVYWEIGHTS
The electoral battle in Karur remains, at its core, a contest between the Dravidian heavyweights — the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), despite the impact of Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). The campaign has been relatively subdued in recent days, though both sides accuse each other of distributing cash to voters. “This is the sad state of affairs of today’s politics,” remarked a party cadre. The constituency has long revolved around two prom-

inent leaders — V Senthil Balaji and MR Vijayabhaskar. Balaji won the seat three times — in 2006 and 2011 as an AIADMK candidate, and later with the DMK in 2021 when he defeated Vijayabhaskar by a margin of 12,448 votes, in an election that witnessed a high turnout of nearly 85 per cent. Vijayabhaskar tasted victory once in 2016. This time, though, Vijayabhaskar is confident of defeating the lesser known DMK opponent, Aasee M Thiagarajan, a close confidante of Senthil Balaji, who has moved to contest from Coimbatore (South). “This could make it easier for Vijayabhaskar to reclaim the seat,” said Manickam, a long-time resident. Meanwhile, the memory of the stampede still lingers in Velusampyuram on the Karur-Erode road, where a crowd of over 27,000 gathered despite permission for just 10,000 for a rally of TVK. Near the Iyappa Bakery, where the incident unfolded, residents acknowledge the tragedy but downplay its electoral impact.



BITTER MEMORIES. Velusampyuram, the place where the stampede took place during actor-politician Vijay’s rally last year BUJOY GHOSH

“It was a terrible incident, but we have to move forward and ensure that it is not repeated,” said Gopal, a college graduate and ardent Vijay supporter. Among younger voters, enthusiasm for Vijay remains strong, even if many concede that the immediate contest is between the DMK and the AIADMK. “This is Senthil Balaji’s stronghold, and he will ensure his party wins,” said a voter who supported the DMK in the last election, but is undecided this time.

Grassroots mobilisation is already underway. A party worker noted that in his ward of around 900 voters, 5-8 per cent are aged between 18 and 35, with several leaning towards Vijay. “People feel the Dravidian parties have ruled for dec-

ades. They want change,” said Akash, a 32-year-old cab driver, who plans to vote for the TVK. “Even if Vijay doesn’t win now, his presence will shape future elections.” **A MIX OF COMMUNITIES**
Karur’s social fabric is complex, with Gounders, Naickers and Chettiar forming dominant communities, alongside a significant Scheduled Caste population. The constituency faces persistent issues — public safety, caste disparities and environmental concerns. In August 2025, a 200-foot-long “wall of untouchability” built on government land triggered outrage before being demolished. Karur’s thriving textile and dyeing industries continue to pose environmental risks, particularly because of chemical waste affecting groundwater in nearby villages. Yet, these concerns appear sidelined in the current campaign. “Today, no one is talking about social or environmental issues — only about Vijay’s impact,” said Kuppam, a regular at Iyappa Bakery.

QUICKLY.
‘23% candidates have criminal cases in West Bengal’s Phase II’

New Delhi: Around 23 per cent candidates in the fray in the second phase of West Bengal polls have declared criminal cases against themselves, while 22 per cent are crorepatis, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR). Of the 1,445 candidates analysed, 338 (23 per cent) had declared criminal cases against themselves and 295 (20 per cent) had declared serious criminal cases against themselves, the report showed. While 16 candidates had declared cases of murder, 80 face attempt to murder charges, it said. Among the major parties, 102 (72 per cent) out of the 141 candidates analysed from the BJP, 49 (35 per cent) out of 142 candidates from the TMC, 51 out of 100 candidates from the CPI(M) and 37 (26 per cent) out of 142 analysed from the Congress had declared criminal cases against themselves in their poll affidavits, said the ADR report. Of the 142 constituencies, 63 (44 per cent) are “red alert” constituencies that have three or more candidates with criminal cases, it said. Of the 1,445 candidates, 321 (22 per cent) have assets worth over ₹1 crore. Among the major parties, 103 (73 per cent) out of the 142 candidates analysed from the TMC, 73 (52 per cent) out of 141 candidates analysed from the BJP, 36 (25 per cent) out of 142 candidates from the Congress and 33 (33 per cent) out of 100 candidates analysed from the CPI(M) have declared assets valued more than ₹1 crore. The average of assets per candidate is ₹1.21 crore, it added. The average assets per candidate for 142 TMC candidates analysed is ₹5.05 crore, ₹3.28 crore for 141 BJP candidates, ₹1.22 crore for 100 CPI(M) and ₹1.04 crore for 142 Congress candidates. **PHOTO**



TAMIL NADU UNDER DMK

Rich but under debt burden

Lokeshwarri SK
Chennai

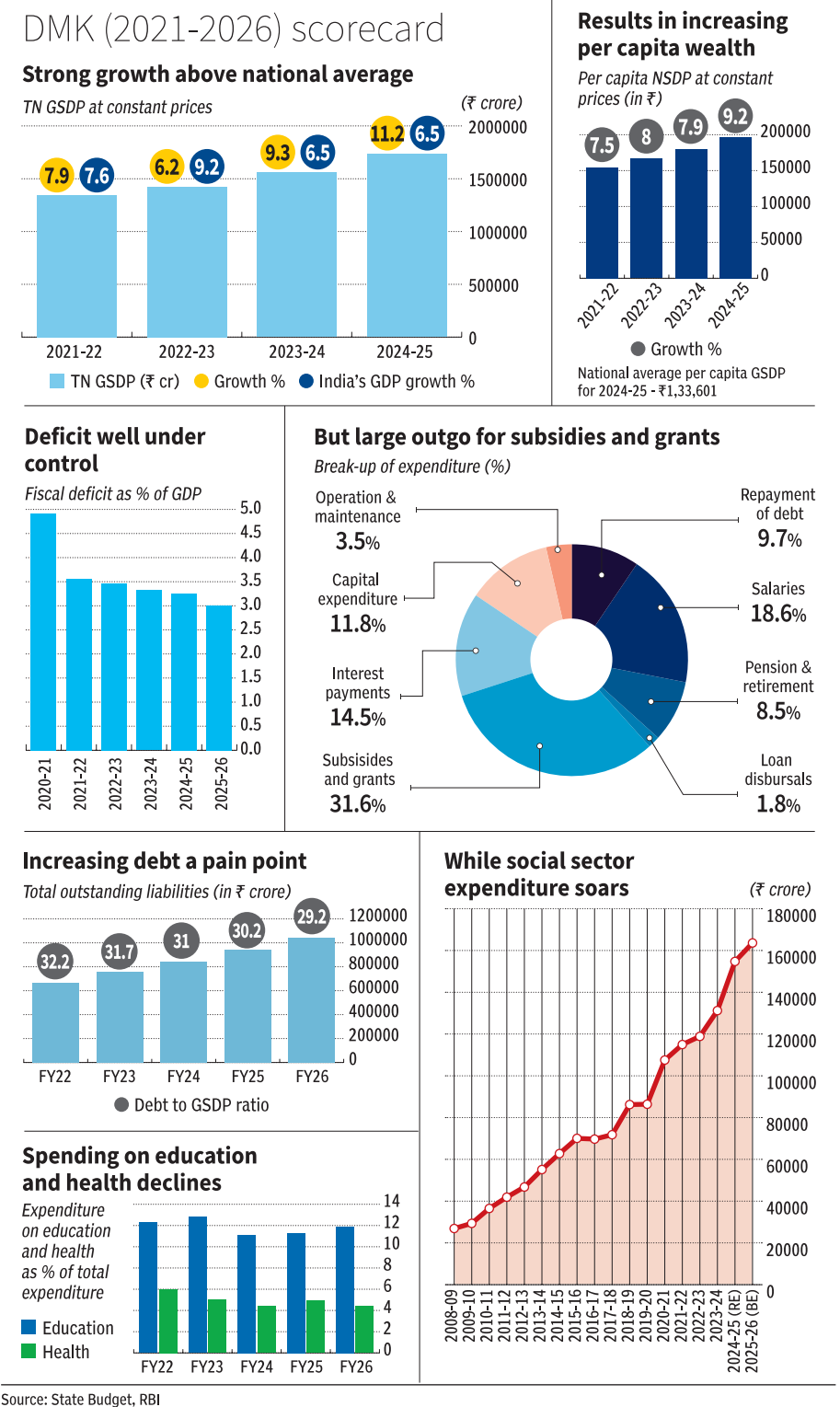
The MK Stalin-led Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) began its latest term in May 2021 when the country was still in the grip of the Covid-19 pandemic.

DATA FOCUS.

But growth in Tamil Nadu gathered pace from FY24, led by manufacturing and exports and supported by services. Per-capita GSDP growth has also been among the best in the country in the last two years. But the DMK’s management of finances leaves much to be desired. High spending on subsidies and grants is resulting in the State borrowing heavily and piling up a large debt. This is impacting capital investments, as well as spending on essentials such as education and health.

STRONG GROWTH
Tamil Nadu, with a strong industrial base, a thriving services sector, good port connectivity and high degree of urbanisation, has been among the top performers among Indian States for many years now. It recently moved to the second spot in terms of GSDP after Maharashtra. Growth in the first two years of the DMK’s term was tepid due to the pandemic impacting MSMEs, smaller businesses and the agricultural sector. But the economy has picked up pace since FY24, with growth in FY25 at 11.2 per cent being the fastest among other States. Per-capita GSDP has also been growing strongly with the number for FY25 standing at ₹1,96,309, far above the national average of ₹1,33,601.

IN A SWEET SPOT
Tamil Nadu has been in a sweet spot since FY23, with both the manufacturing sector, which accounts for 33 per cent of the GSVa, and the services sector (54 per cent of GSVa) managing to clock high growth. Manufacturing benefited due to the thrust on electronics and automobiles, led by smartphone and electric vehicles. Though the services sector in India has been facing challenges due to AI adoption, the setting up of global capability centres in Chennai and other cities of Tamil Nadu has ensured continued growth in this space. The State ranked fifth in garnering FDI flows between



2019 and 2025. Despite the strong growth in the economy, the DMK government’s management of State finances has been found wanting. Though the State has the potential to raise enough revenue to fund its expenses, its thrust on welfarism results in sub-optimal revenue collection, resulting in large deficit and debt. **FISCAL DEFICIT**
Its fiscal deficit has been largely under control, hovering between 3 and 3.5 per cent since the pandemic. But the DMK government has been piling on a large debt. Tamil Nadu’s accumulated debt of ₹10,42,858 crore towards the end of March 2026

Tamil Nadu, with a strong industrial base, a thriving services sector, good port connectivity and high degree of urbanisation, has been among the top performers for many years now is the highest among all States and UTs. The debt has been growing at a faster rate since 2021, with Tamil Nadu overtaking Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Karnataka in outstanding debt in this period. As a result, the debt to GSDP ratio has been at elevated levels over the last five years. This ratio was well under the FRBM mandate of 25 per cent prior to 2020. **HIGHER SPENDING**
The quality of expenditure is also a concern with higher spending on subsidies and social welfare measures, and allocation to education and health declining over the last five years. Capital outlay as a percentage of the GSDP has been stagnant at 1.5 per cent over the last three years, and development expenditure as a percentage of the GSDP is also quite low at around 7 per cent in FY26.

Our Bureau
Chennai

On the last day of the election campaign for the Tamil Nadu elections, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu urged voters to back the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK)-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA), arguing that only a “double-engine government” could accelerate growth and infrastructure in the State.

As TN voters yearn for change, Vijay emerges as a decisive factor

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

“We need a change,” say people, especially in places such as Tiruchirappalli, Thanjavur, Mayiladuthurai, Coimbatore, Erode and Karur. When asked what sort of change they want, they say they have tried the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), but are not satisfied with their work. “Why should we not give actor Vijay’s Tamizhaga Vettri Kazhagam a chance?” they ask.

KEY MESSAGE
The big message ringing loud and clear ahead of the Assembly elections in Tamil Nadu is that Vijay’s TVK is emerging as a game-changer. “TVK could decide if the DMK or the AIADMK will win in almost every constituency,” says an observer in Tiruchirappalli, who did not wish to be identified. The surge in support, observers say, is rooted in the growing desire for political change. Many voters, especially the youth, feel the State has been dominated for far too long by the DMK and the AIADMK, which have alternated in power for over five decades since 1967. Despite the State voting for one of the two Dravidian parties, the same civic issues continue to plague urban and rural centres. TVK’s influence, though, seems to be more in the urban areas than in the rural ones, going by what locals say in Tiruchirappalli or Thanjavur. “We have 13 votes in our family. All will go to Vijay. In fact, all 935 votes in our area are TVK’s. We voted for the



STAR ATTRACTION. TVK leader Vijay on the last day of campaigning in Chennai on Tuesday BUJOY GHOSH

DMK last time,” says M Prakash at the Southern Grand Trunk Road junction in Tiruchirappalli. “We need a change from the governance of the two Dravidian parties,” says Ram, a 31-year-old cab driver in Coimbatore, who voted for the DMK in 2021 but now plans to support the TVK. Shanthi, a 48-year-old restaurant worker in Coimbatore, echoed a similar sentiment. “We need an alternative,” she says. Balamurgan G, a small trader in Thiruvaiyaru, says 12 of his family’s votes will go to the TVK. They had voted for the AIADMK in the last elections. Vinitha, a housewife in Virudhunagar’s Kammappatti, says her vote is for Vijay. The reason: She likes him. **SEEKING A CHANGE**
A group of flower vendors at the Chhataram bus stand in Tiruchirappalli say they want a change and will vote for the TVK. The yearning for a change stems from the law and order situation and corruption witnessed during the current DMK regime.

made the difference for India’s growth. Emphasising Tamil Nadu’s historical legacy, rich culture and contribution to nation-building, Naidu questioned if the State had kept pace with emerging economic hubs, such as Hyderabad and Bengaluru. “Tamil Nadu has produced some of the finest minds — from CV Raman and Srinivasa Ramanujan to APJ Abdul Kalam. But the question today is if we are leveraging that strength fully?” he asked. Tamil Nadu has missed

out to other States such as Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka, with some of the brightest migrating to various countries, he added. **INFRA GAPS**
Highlighting infrastructure gaps in Tamil Nadu, Naidu pointed to airports and urban development, drawing comparisons with cities such as Hyderabad and Bengaluru. He said public-private partnerships and proactive reforms were key to attracting investments and generating employment.

pur believes that though Vijay may not dramatically alter the outcome this time, he has already unsettled established players. Rajalakshmi from Thiruvaidaimaruthur village in Thanjavur says she will not succumb to pressure from her children and would vote for the AIADMK. While the actor is an undeniable crowd puller, Vijay’s party leaders are finding it hard to connect with the masses. A former Congress MLA told *businessline* that at least 25 per cent of the community that Vijay belongs to will vote for the TVK. “The other minority community will back the DMK,” he says. Syed Mohammed Shahjahan, an autodriver in Mayiladuthurai, says his community will vote *en bloc* for the DMK. On how his kids will vote, he says, “Most of them are abroad. Only one is here; who cares how he votes?” On the women folk, he says they will have to be “brainwashed”. The Tiruchirappalli observer says a good number of women from Shahjahan’s community would probably vote for the National Democratic Alliance, given some of the reforms such as the triple talaq law. The observer had a simple calculation on how the TVK will get votes. Tamil Nadu has 5.75 crore voters. New voters make up 12.5 lakh, and at least 7 lakh will vote for the TVK. Among the 23 lakh voters under 30 years of age, at least 15 lakh could vote for Vijay’s party. “We see him getting a little over one crore votes,” he says. If there is voter turnout of 80 per cent and more, Vijay and his fledgling TVK could garner at least 20 per cent, says the observer. With inputs from Balaji R, T E Rajasimhan and Rohan Das

QUICKLY.

Gold slips on firm dollar ahead of US-Iran talks



Gold prices fell as the dollar firmed, investors remaining cautious as they looked to tentative US-Iran talks and a Senate confirmation hearing for Fed Chairman nominee Kevin Warsh. Spot gold was down 0.9 per cent to \$4,776.49 per ounce at 1333 GMT. US gold futures for June delivery fell 0.7 per cent to \$4,795.40. Silver fell 1.6 per cent to \$78.64, platinum lost 0.8 per cent to \$2,073.05. REUTERS

Copper in limbo as traders await Iran war, Fed signals

Copper prices lacked direction as investors waited for news on whether peace talks between the US and Iran would go ahead, as well as a Fed chair confirmation hearing. Benchmark three-month copper on the LME was up 0.1 per cent at \$13,288 a tonne. Aluminium added 0.3 per cent to \$3,568, while zinc was the biggest gainer, rising 1.1 per cent to \$3,447.50. REUTERS

Crude oil steady as trade eyes ceasefire talks



London: Crude oil prices fell on expectations that peace talks between the US and Iran will take place this week. Brent crude futures edged down by 18 cents to \$95.30 a barrel by 1255 GMT. US WTI for May lost 30 cents to \$89.31. REUTERS

Centre proposes to increase minimum distance between new sugar mills to 25 km

POLICY NOD. State governments will take a call if any existing plant plans to raise production capacity

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Amid stagnant or falling sugar consumption, the Union government has proposed to increase the distance between two sugar mills to 25 km from the current 15 km if anyone wishes to set up a new factory. Besides, it has proposed that the State government will take a call if any existing plant wants to increase sugar production capacity.

The draft Sugarcane (Control) Order 2026 was published online by the Union Food Ministry on Tuesday for public feedback by May 20.

“Notwithstanding anything contained in Clause 6, no new sugar factory shall be

set up within the radius of 25 km of any existing sugar factory or another new sugar factory in a State or two or more States; provided that the State government may with the prior approval of the Union government, where it considers necessary and expedient in public interest, notify such minimum distance higher than 25 km or different minimum distances not less than 25 km for different regions in their respective States,” the draft order said.

2025-26 CONSUMPTION
For expansion of the capacity of existing sugar factories, the State government or any other authority appointed by the Union government shall assess the sugarcane availability, cultivable area, average

yield, operational days of the sugar mill and also not adversely affecting the cane availability of neighbouring sugar mills and other related issues for cultivation of sugarcane in the area, the draft order said. Sugar consumption in the 2025-26 season (October-September) is likely to be about 280 lakh tonnes (lt) as in the first half (October-March) of the current season, the sales are estimated to be 141 lt while a similar quantity is seen to be consumed during the second half as well, sources said.

The government had allocated 133 lt of sugar for domestic sales in the first half of the current season.

In 2024-25 season, the actual consumption of sugar was 281 lt, per industry estimates against an allocation



DEMAND PACE. Sugar consumption in the country in 2025-26 (October-September) is estimated at about 280 lt, with the first half (October-March) sales pegged at 141 lt

of 275.5 lt of quota to the mills for domestic sales by the government.

JAGGERY OFFTAKE UP
While many experts attribute the stagnant or falling

domestic sugar consumption to growing health consciousness among the public, others said sugar is getting replaced by jaggery in many cases.

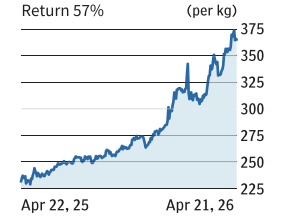
The government last year

amended the Sugar (Control) Order and the Sugarcane (Control) Order by including ‘khandsari’ units (with a capacity of more than 500 TCD) under the purview of regulations, though it is yet to be effectively implemented. Under the law, these units are also supposed to file monthly returns and pay the same rate for sugarcane to farmers as sugar mills pay, as well as being allotted areas from where they have to purchase sugarcane.

There are over 370 khandsari units with a total capacity of about 95,000 tonnes (cane) crushed per day (TCD) in the country. Of these, an estimated 66 units have capacity of more than 500 TCD each, and only these units are covered under the amended order.

COMMODITY CALL.

Aluminium:
Wait for a rise to go short



Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

Aluminium price has been stable so far this week after witnessing a sharp fall last Friday.

The aluminium futures contract traded on the Multi Commodity Exchange surged over 5 per cent to make a high of ₹377.15 per kg on Thursday. But on Friday, the contract tumbled to ₹350.50.

The price has, however, bounced back well from that low and is currently trading at ₹364.

Key resistances for the week are at ₹369 and ₹374. Supports are at ₹354 and ₹350.

Within the range, the bias is slightly inclined towards bearishness.

As long as the contract trades below ₹374, we see high chances for a fall to ₹354-₹350 or even ₹343 in the short term.

The contract must breach ₹374 decisively in order to gain momentum. Only then the upside will open up for a fresh rise to ₹390.

TRADE STRATEGY
Traders can wait for a rise and go short at ₹367 and ₹372. Keep the stop-loss at ₹376 initially. Trail the stop-loss down to ₹365 as soon as the contract falls to ₹361. Revise the stop-loss down to ₹362 and ₹360 when the price falls to ₹360 and ₹358, respectively. Exit the short positions at ₹356.

Volatile geopolitics pose risks to edible oil sector: SEA

Our Bureau
Mangaluru

The Solvent Extractors’ Association of India (SEA) has said that continued geopolitical volatility may have longer-term implications for the edible oil sector in the country.

In his monthly letter to the members of the association, Sanjeev Asthana, President of SEA, said recent developments surrounding the US and Iran had created a fluid and uncertain environment in the Gulf region.

While the temporary ceasefire and brief reopening of the Strait of Hormuz offered some initial relief, the situation had since turned ambiguous, with intermittent disruptions and

conflicting signals. “For our industry, this continues to pose challenges, as shipping routes remain vulnerable, freight costs elevated and trade flows of edible oils and oil meals uncertain, making planning more complex,” he said.

Since the onset of the conflict, prices of crude-linked derivatives such as polyethylene and polypropylene, key inputs in plastic packaging, have risen by 50-60 per cent, placing bottles and plastic wrappers among the weaker links in FMCG supply chains. Packaging typically accounts for 15-25 per cent of product costs, meaning even moderate increases can significantly impact prices of edible oils.

Stating that the overall outlook signals a weaker



INPUT COSTS SURGE. Since the onset of the conflict, prices of crude-linked derivatives such as polyethylene and polypropylene, key inputs in plastic packaging, have risen by 50-60%

monsoon and rising risk, he said the South-West monsoon remains critical for economic growth, as a good kharif harvest supports a strong rural economy.

However, a potential decline in kharif production may lead to food inflation.

This comes amid rising input and fuel costs due to the ongoing US-Iran conflict, adding further pressure on the agriculture sector.

OILMEALS EXPORT HIT
He said the recent geopolitical developments in the

Gulf region had disrupted export of oilmeals to West Asia and Europe due to higher freight costs and shipping challenges.

To mitigate this, there is a need to strengthen efforts in existing and alternative markets.

In this regard, SEA plans to organise a trade delegation of 10-12 leading exporters to key Far East markets in July 2026 to make up for shortfalls and enhance trade opportunities.

India exports nearly 65 per cent of oilmeals to the Far East. West Asia and Europe account for around 20 per cent and 15 per cent of exports, respectively.

PALM OIL TRADE
In another communication, BV Mehta, Executive Dir-

ector of SEA, said the interplay of biodiesel expansion, weather risks and geopolitics is setting the stage for a more constrained global palm oil balance going into 2026-27.

Geopolitical disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz and evolving trade policies were adding layers of uncertainty to global supply chains.

“With Indonesia’s shift toward B50, Malaysia’s to B15 and Thailand’s to B20, it’s quite evident how global palm oil trade is getting tighter in near future! With India’s close partners ramping up their biodiesel mandates and diverting more palm oil toward domestic energy use, it’s bound to result in compressing exportable supplies from the region,” he said.

El Nino likely to emerge between May and July

Our Bureau
Chennai

All major climate models, including those used by Australia’s Bureau of Meteorology, project continued warming of the tropical Pacific, with El Nino possibly emerging between May and July.

While some models indicate an earlier onset, others suggest a more gradual transition, with uncertainty hinging on ocean-atmosphere coupling — a critical factor for sustaining a full-fledged El Nino.

Global climate signals are tilting towards a possible return of the El Nino-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) warming later this year, even as near-term forecasts point to continued above-normal temperatures worldwide.

According to Australia’s Bureau of Meteorology, the ENSO system is currently in a neutral phase but is showing

clear signs of warming.

The latest Nino3.4 index, a key measure of Pacific Ocean temperatures, stood at -0.27°C for the week ending April 12, well within the neutral range.

However, the index has been steadily rising since the end of the southern hemisphere summer, supported by a recent pulse of sub-surface warming that is expected to lift sea surface temperatures further in the coming weeks.

WARMING TREND
Overall, climate models point to a warm global baseline with regionally varied rainfall patterns, while the growing likelihood of El Nino later in 2026 adds a layer of uncertainty to weather outcomes in the months ahead. Short-term atmospheric signals also reinforce the warming trend.

Meanwhile, the 30-day Southern Oscillation Index has dropped sharply to -7.7,

reflecting shifting pressure patterns across the Pacific, although longer duration indices remain positive.

IOD NEUTRAL
Alongside ENSO, the Indian Ocean Dipole is currently neutral, with an index of +0.06°C.

Most models suggest it will remain neutral through late autumn, though there is a growing possibility of a positive phase developing during winter and spring, a shift that can influence monsoon behaviour in the Indian subcontinent.

Forecast uncertainty around the IOD remains elevated, with models showing a wide range of outcomes.

The APEC Climate Center’s latest global seasonal outlook points to above-normal rainfall over India.

For India, the combination of a neutral-to-warming ENSO phase and the possibility of a positive IOD later in the year could prove pivotal.

Allana-Captain Fresh JV to retail animal protein products

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

The Allana Group, along with its subsidiary Indian Poultry Alliance (IPA), and Captain Fresh, a global packaged seafood player, has announced the incorporation of Indian Retail Alliance Private Limited (IRAPL), a joint venture that will build India’s first at-scale, organised fresh protein retail ecosystem.

Allana Group and Captain Fresh hold 51 per cent and 49 per cent, respectively, in the new entity. Captain Fresh will bring its seafood supply chain capabilities, along with the omni-channel technology stack, under its retail brand ChopServe.

This will be complemented by the Allana Group’s deep expertise and best-in-class infrastructure across chicken, RTC and protein processing.

Together, the platform aims to combine the product and supply chain leadership

of both partners with market-facing retail entrepreneurs to organise India’s fragmented protein industry.

The platform will retail fresh proteins, including seafood, chicken and mutton, serving customers through stores, shop-in-shop formats and HoReCa channels, creating a unified demand network for fresh proteins across India.

NETWORK EXPANSION
“With a vision to build a 4,000-store network in India within the next 4 years, we will create a scalable ecosystem where local operators can leverage strong sourcing, technology, retail execution and shared infrastructure to build profitable businesses,” said Asim Allana, Family Promoter, Allana Group.

“We realised that the opportunity in fresh protein retail demands strong product leadership, coupled with entrepreneurial energy at the distribution end,” said Utham Gowda, CMD and Group CEO, Captain Fresh.

Overcoming US hurdles, seafood exports up 15% in 2025-26

V Sajeev Kumar
Kochi

India’s seafood exports increased by over 15 per cent in value to ₹72,325.82 crore (\$8.28 billion) and 13 per cent in volume to 19.32 lakh tonnes in FY26, despite facing problems with shipments to the US.

In 2024-25, exports totalled ₹62,408.45 (\$7.435 billion) in value and 16.98 lakh tonnes in volume.

Provisional data released by the Marine Products Export Development Authority (Mpeda) said frozen shrimp continued to be the primary growth driver, contributing ₹47,973.13 crore (\$5.51 billion) and accounting for over two-thirds of total export earnings.

Shrimp shipments grew 4.6 per cent in volume and 6.35 per cent in value.

OTHER MARKETS
The US retained its position as the largest export destination,



with imports totalling \$2.32 billion. However, shipments to the US declined by 19.8 per cent in volume and 14.5 per cent in value, reflecting primarily the impact of reciprocal tariffs.

The slowdown in the US market was offset by strong growth in alternative markets such as China, the EU and South-East Asian countries.

Exports to China, the second-largest destination, rose 22.7 per cent in value and 20.1 per cent in volume. The EU posted strong gains,

with exports increasing by 37.9 per cent in value and 35.2 per cent in volume.

EXPANSION IN S-E ASIA
South-East Asia also recorded significant expansion, with growth of over 36.1 per cent in value and 28.2 per cent in volume.

Exports to Japan grew 6.55 per cent in value, while those to West Asia showed a marginal decline due to the turmoil in the region during the lag end of the financial year.

Several individual markets registered strong double-digit growth, underscoring a clear shift towards diversification amid trade headwinds in traditional markets.

On the product side, exports of frozen fish, squid, cuttlefish, dried items and live products showed positive momentum, while chilled products declined.

Exports of surimi, fishmeal and fish oil also reported improved performance.

Cotton Corporation sells over half the produce procured during 2025-26 season

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The state-run Cotton Corporation of India (CCI) has sold over half of the natural fibre procured in the 2025-26 season at the minimum support price, driven by strong demand from mills and traders. The CCI procured 105 lakh bales (170 kg each) this season, up from 100.16 lakh bales last year.

As of Monday, CCI’s sales had crossed 55 lakh bales, said Lalit Kumar Gupta, Chairman and Managing Director. Steady offtake over the past two months, despite a rally in global prices, underscores robust demand from both mills and the trade.



STRONG RALLY. ICE futures have breached 80 cents per pound for July delivery, marking a 30% jump since early March

On Tuesday, the CCI raised its selling price by ₹200 per candy (356 kg), taking the total increase this week to ₹800.

Last week, prices were raised by ₹1,500 per candy. The cumulative hike this season exceeds ₹6,000. “From a

low of about ₹55,000 per candy, current prices are around ₹61,000,” Gupta said. “Even after the increase, our prices remain the cheapest globally,” he added.

International prices have risen over 25 per cent, while domestic prices have gained

15-20 per cent. Domestic rates are still 2-3 per cent lower than global levels, which are about ₹63,500-64,000.

The CCI’s price revisions track the global uptrend. Since early March, international prices have climbed nearly 30 per cent. Cotton futures on the ICE rose from about 62 cents per pound in early March to over 80 cents, hovering around 81 cents for July delivery on Tuesday.

Despite the successive price hikes, sales remained strong, with CCI stocks dropping below 50 lakh bales. “Mill demand is firm, with yarn orders tied up for the next 3-4 months. Mills will continue to cover their requirements,” Gupta said.

As cotton prices rise, textile industry seeks removal of 11 per cent duty on imports

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

As domestic cotton prices continue to rise tracking global clues, a worried textile industry has urged the government to allow duty-free imports of the fibre crop to safeguard export competitiveness and stabilise the value chain.

Cotton prices have been climbing steadily in recent weeks, putting pressure across the textile ecosystem — from spinning mills to garment exporters. Industry stakeholders warn that the sustained price surge is eroding margins, particularly for exporters operating on long-term contracts with limited

flexibility to absorb input cost increases.

“Cotton price increase will definitely affect the whole value chain because it is rising steeply day by day,” said K Selvaraju, Secretary General of The Southern India Mills Association (SIMA), highlighting that garments, which rely on fabric inputs, are especially vulnerable due to the absence of sufficient price cushioning.

FACING HEADWINDS
The timing of the cotton price rally is particularly challenging as India’s textile exports are already facing headwinds due to geopolitical disruptions, including the ongoing tensions in West Asia that have affected de-



mand in key markets. While yarn exports have remained relatively stable, supported by demand from China, the broader export segment is under strain.

Spinning mills, for now, have managed to sustain operations despite elevated cotton prices. However, if the trend continues, even this segment could face disruptions, Selvaraju said, adding that there was a dearth of quality cotton in the country. The untimely rains last year damaged more than half the cotton crop, resulting in quality issues. As a result, the mills are not only grappling with tight supplies but also limited availability of quality cotton.

Selvaraju said cotton production is around 290 lakh bales, lower than the domestic requirement of around 330 lakh bales.

To bridge the gap, the industry is calling for the removal of the 11 per cent import duty on cotton from May till October, a window that would cover the lean supply period before fresh arrivals begin.

QUICKLY.

Tata Steel, SMS Group tie up to cut carbon footprint

Mumbai: Tata Steel has entered into definitive agreements with Paul Wurth, SA (Luxembourg), part of the SMS Group GmbH, to implement the world's first EASyMelt (electrically-assisted syngas smelter) technology. Tata Steel intends to proceed with the first industrial demonstration of this technology in the 'E' Blast Furnace at its Jamshedpur works in a phased manner. The project aims to cut carbon emissions by over 50 per cent compared to the blast furnace's baseline operation.

OUR BUREAU

MoD pact with Electro, BEML to buy tank parts

New Delhi: The Defence Ministry on Tuesday signed contracts worth ₹975 crore for the procurement of critical equipment for T-72 and T-90 tanks of the Army. The contracts were inked in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh in Delhi. The Ministry, in a statement, said it has signed contracts with Bharat Earth Movers Limited (BEML) and Electro Pneumatics and Hydraulics (India) Pvt Ltd for the "procurement of TRAWL Assembly for T-72/T-90 tanks, at a cost of ₹975 crore".

For Stovekraft, the next phase of growth simmers on electric cooking

Aishwarya Kumar
Bengaluru

India's kitchens are steadily moving toward electrification, and Stovekraft is betting big on that shift to drive its next phase of growth. Managing Director Rajendra Gandhi said the company expects electric cooking appliances, ranging from induction cooktops to rice cookers and air fryers, to emerge as its strongest growth engine as consumers increasingly move away from traditional LPG-based cooking.

"The next wave of growth is clearly coming from electric cooking," Gandhi said, pointing to rising adoption and a broader policy push to reduce dependence on gas. The maker of Pigeon brand appliances is already seeing strong momentum in the segment. As demand has scaled up, the company has significantly ramped up production of electric cooktops in recent months. The company saw a 4-times spike in the average weekly sales of induction cooktops on e-commerce channels.

E-COMM, EXPORTS

"We currently manufacture around 2 lakh units of induction cooktops monthly at our facility at Harohalli, Karnataka, and plan to ramp

RBI issues 'Digital Payments E-mandate Framework, 2026'

RULES SET. Consolidates norms, introduces new ones for recurring online payments

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The Reserve Bank of India on Tuesday issued the 'Digital Payments — E-mandate Framework, 2026,' under which customers opting for e-mandates must complete a one-time registration process that requires additional factor authentication (AFA), and issuers will be required to send a pre-transaction notification at least 24 hours before a charge/debit and a post-transaction notification.

The framework, which consolidates existing guidelines and introduces a comprehensive set of rules to govern recurring digital transactions across payment systems, has also fixed transaction limits and velocity check.

So, all recurring transactions up to ₹15,000 may be authorised without AFA while higher amounts will be subject to AFA.

Further, payment of insurance premium, subscription to mutual funds and credit card bill payments may be made without AFA up to



PRO-CUSTOMER. No charges can be levied on the customer for availing of the e-mandate facility for recurring transactions

₹1,00,000 per transaction.

The RBI emphasised that no charges can be levied to the customer for availing of the e-mandate facility for recurring transactions. In case of cards, existing e-mandate (s) can be mapped to re-issued cards.

AUTHENTICATION

Under the framework, the e-mandate will be registered only after successful validation of AFA, in addition to the normal process required by the issuer.

Every e-mandate registered by the issuer will specify the validity period of the e-mandate. The issuer will provide the customer a facility to modify the validity

period or withdraw the e-mandate at any point of time.

The e-mandate may be for either a pre-specified fixed amount or for a variable amount subject to the overall cap fixed by the RBI, according to the framework.

In the case of variable e-mandates, the issuer will provide the customer a facility to specify the maximum value of any recurring transaction.

The customer will be given a facility to choose or change a mode among available options (SMS, email, etc.) for receiving the pre-transaction notification from the issuer. Any modification in, or withdrawal of, an existing e-mandate will re-

quire AFA validation by the issuer.

BOTH NOTIFICATIONS

The pre and post-transaction notification will, at the minimum, inform the customer about the merchant's name, transaction amount, date/time of debit, reference number of e-mandate, reason for debit, i.e., the e-mandate registered by the customer.

The issuer will provide the customer the facility to opt-out of any particular transaction or the e-mandate. However, pre-transaction notification is not required for e-mandates registered to auto-replenish balances of FASTag, and the National Common Mobility Card (NCMC).

DISPUTE RESOLUTION

The RBI said an appropriate dispute redressal system has to be put in place by the issuer to facilitate the customer to lodge grievance/s.

Further, instructions on limiting the liability of customers for unauthorised transactions will be applicable to recurring transactions under e-mandates as well.

Akshayakalpa makes haste slowly in fast-churning organic dairy biz

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Pravin More, a marginal farmer from Nune village in Satara's farming belt with just 3-4 cattle, has seen the milk yield of his herd rise from 3-4 litres a day to 12-15 litres over the past three years after shifting from commercial feed mixes to homegrown organic fodder under Akshayakalpa's farmed model.

That model, built in Tip-tur, Karnataka, underpins a business producing 2.1-2.5 lakh litres of milk daily and serving nearly 70,000 households in Bengaluru, Chennai and Hyderabad. Revenues have risen from about ₹350 crore in FY25 to an estimated ₹550-600 crore in FY26, with a trajectory toward ₹700 crore. The company is now looking to replicate the system in Maharashtra, with a ₹200 crore processing hub and farmer network coming up in Mawal, near Pune.

Industry analysts say Country Delight is estimated to have crossed around ₹2,000 crore in revenue in FY26 and carries a valuation of ₹6,950 crore, while KisanKconnect is in the ₹200-400 crore range with a valuation of 690 crore. In com-



Akshayakalpa Co-founder and CEO Shashi Kumar

parison, Akshayakalpa has a valuation of ₹1,600-1,700 crore, but is more deeply integrated into its supply chain.

FARM TO FORMULA

Akshayakalpa Co-founder and CEO Shashi Kumar built the business over a decade by focusing on farm-level control rather than procurement. At the core of that argument is feed. Much of India's dairy supply depends on commercial concentrate feeds which, if not managed carefully, can introduce contaminants such as aflatoxins, something downstream testing cannot fully eliminate. "You can reject milk, but you cannot fix the problem unless you fix what the animal is eating," Kumar said.

That approach stands in contrast to platforms such as Country Delight and KisanKconnect, which scaled rapidly by aggregating supply and testing quality at collection points. Akshayakalpa instead works with over 2,800 certified organic farmers across multi-year cycles, managing soil health, cattle feed and certification to build a closed-loop system where quality is controlled at source.

There is also a more immediate competitive pressure the growth numbers don't fully capture: Amul. The dairy cooperative is entering organics at relatively modest price premiums, while FMCG majors such as ITC, Tata Consumer and Reliance are shaping the category through acquisitions.

"We don't enter a market until the farm ecosystem is ready," Kumar said. "For us, expansion is supply-first, not geography-first."

"We are creating local food grids," Kumar said, describing a decentralised model where each region develops its own supply base rather than relying on centralised sourcing. At its core, the model is built on farmer economics. "If farmers don't make money, they won't produce good food," he said.

India Inc takes to project-based hiring for skilled talent

Rohan Das
Chennai

A few years ago, a major Indian bank offered 100 per cent virtual project-based roles for 8-12 months.

It hoped to attract talent that preferred flexible commitments across domains like technology, digital banking, risk modelling, virtual sales and auditing. The bank planned to hire 800-1,000 employees.

FIXED JOB TITLE

Similarly, a FMCG giant recently unveiled a flexible em-

ployment model that allows freelancers to work on projects without a fixed job title or multi-year contracts. This, at a time when the said company had enacted a temporary global hiring freeze for three months and an ongoing cost-saving programme that involves the rationalisation of 7,500 full-time roles.

These instances point to a structural shift in workforce models in India as corporates are filling the gap left by the departure of full-time employees through smaller project-based roles.

Speaking to *businessline*,



The trend is now expanding across industries such as BFSI, consumer businesses, healthcare and manufacturing

HR analysts and experts said there had been an increasing shift from broad-based head-

count growth to targeted project-based hiring for shorter durations.

While earlier more pronounced in sectors like technology services, they added that the trend is now expanding across industries such as BFSI, consumer businesses, healthcare and manufacturing.

Neeti Sharma, CEO, TeamLease Digital, said she believes that companies are steadily building an 'elastic workforce' layer. "Organisations are rethinking how work gets done, breaking it into modular, outcome-linked pieces that can be de-

ployed more flexibly. And this strategy includes bringing in talent for shorter durations or projects with 'specialised' skill sets without increasing the amount of full-time roles."

Peush Saproo, Associate Director & Head Sales — Permanent Recruitment, Ad-ecco India, suggested that nearly 35-40 per cent of Indian employers are redesigning roles to become more project-led with a 25 per cent rise in demand for such roles in FY26 with demand particularly pronounced in sectors like manufacturing, pharmaceuticals and BFSI.

'Q-comm discounts plateau as firms balance growth, profitability'

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Discounting in India's fast-growing quick commerce and e-grocery market is showing signs of moderation after a steady rise over the past two years, as platforms recalibrate strategies amid intensifying competition and pressure on unit economics, according to a Jefferies report.

A mystery shopping exercise across major platforms in Bengaluru found that grocery baskets saw discounts ranging between 15 per cent and 24 per cent compared with maximum retail prices (MRP), with an average discount of about 17 per cent. Flipkart Minutes'

XtraSaver feature emerged as the most aggressive, offering up to 24 per cent discount, followed by DMart Ready and Flipkart Minutes at around 23 per cent, and Amazon Now at 22 per cent.

However, the report noted that discounting had eased compared with December levels across most platforms, suggesting a shift towards more disciplined pricing.

Analysts said the moderation indicates that companies may be prioritising margins after a prolonged period of aggressive customer acquisition spending.

PERSONAL CARE

Category-level trends remain uneven. Personal care products saw the steepest discounts at 35 per cent,



SPEED VS PRICE. Platforms such as Blinkit and Swiggy Instamart, which focus on rapid deliveries, offered discounts of around 15 per cent, among the lowest in the cohort

while packaged food and staples were discounted by 20 per cent and 19 per cent respectively. Dairy products, a low-margin category, saw minimal discounting at just 5 per cent.

The analysis also high-

lights a clear trade-off: Speed versus price. Platforms such as Blinkit and Swiggy Instamart, which focus on rapid deliveries, were not the cheapest option for any product in the sample basket and offered discounts of

A year after Pahalgam attack, tourism sector in Kashmir struggles to get back on its feet

Gulzar Bhat
Pahalgam

Most taxis at the tourist taxi stand No 2 in Pahalgam sit idle, as arrivals remain subdued compared with levels before April 22 last year.

The decline follows the deadly attack in the nearby Baisaran meadows, where terrorists killed 25 tourists and a local resident, dealing a severe blow to the region's tourism-dependent economy.

One year on, the impact persists.

"Our work has reduced to around 60 per cent," said Gulzar Ahmad, Vice-President of the taxi stand number 2. The stand has a fleet of around 600 cabs, while another facility in the area, taxi stand number 1, has about 250 vehicles.

ON & OFF ACCESS

Baisaran Valley and Chand-



INSTABILITY PERSISTS. The Pahalgam Pony Owners Union head said that 5,500 ponywallahs in the area depend on tourism

wari have been off-limits to tourists since the attack. Although Chandwari was briefly reopened, locals said it was shut again about two months ago.

Abdul Waheed Wani, President of the Pahalgam Pony Owners Union, said many ponywallahs were forced to sell their animals as they could no longer afford to feed them.

Wani was among the first

responders who ferried injured people to hospital. He said about 5,500 pony operators depend on tourism in the area.

Qazi Tauseef, spokesperson of the Kashmir Economic Alliance, said that the attack dealt a blow not only to tourism but to the broader business ecosystem of the Valley. He believes that the sustained recovery depends on two critical factors — res-

toration of consistent tourist confidence and stronger institutional support.

ARRIVALS DROP BY HALF Between May 2025 and April 2026, Pahalgam recorded around 4.51 lakh domestic tourists, marking a drop of 65 to 70 per cent compared with earlier years.

Following the attack, authorities shut at least 48 destinations. While 41 have since been reopened in phases after security reviews, the rest remain closed, weighing on local businesses.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah told the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly on February 19 that all sites would be reopened by May.

Officials said further reopening would depend on comprehensive security assessments and the implementation of safety protocols to ensure the secure movement of visitors.

Telangana mulls joint investment panel with Norway

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Telangana plans to set up a joint working group with Norway to attract investments. This was proposed by Telangana Minister for IT & Industries D Sridhar Babu in a meeting with a Norwegian delegation led by May-Elin Stener, the Norwegian Ambassador to India, at the Secretariat here on Tuesday.

Speaking on the occasion, the Minister said Telangana was "highly suitable" for investments in the areas of healthcare and life sciences, among others.

Describing Norway as a "global leader" in clean energy, sustainable infrastructure, electric mobility, climate innovation, among others, Sridhar Babu invited investments from Norway, according to a release.

Telangana Grameena Bank's FY26 profit up 90% at ₹1,283 cr

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

The Telangana Grameena Bank's net profit increased 90 per cent at ₹1,283 crore in the financial year ended March 31, 2026, compared to the previous fiscal year.

"FY26 has been a truly outstanding year for Telangana Grameena Bank. Our profit after tax has nearly doubled — up 89.96 per cent to ₹1,282.84 crore. This jump is the result of our steady focus on prudent lending, digital innovation and strengthening our roots in semi-urban and rural Telangana," K Prathapa Reddy, Chairman, Telangana Grameena Bank, said in a release.

The total deposits grew 7.58 per cent to ₹34,604 crore, while gross advances increased 12 per cent to ₹46,547 crore.

Total business crossed ₹81,152 crore, regis-



Total deposits grew 7.58% to ₹34,604 crore, while gross advances went up 12% to ₹46,547 crore

tering a 10.14 per cent growth. The net interest margin (NIM) improved to 4.33 per cent from 3.99 per cent and yield on advances stood at 9.83 per cent.

Gross non-performing assets (GNPA) improved to 1.98 per cent of gross advances from 2.1 per cent last year, while net non-performing assets (NNPA) remained at zero per cent of net advances.

ElevenLabs targets deeper India play with office, language expansion

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

ElevenLabs is planning to set up an office in India as it sharpens focus on the country, which has emerged as a large enterprise market and its fastest-growing region, according to a senior executive.

"India is the largest enterprise market outside the US, and the fastest-growing one as well. Within just five quarters of a meaningful go-to-market presence in the country, we have hundreds of customers," said Karthik Rajaram, General Manager and Country Head for India, ElevenLabs.

The company operates with an aspirational 'Big HairY Audacious Goal' (BHAG) for India, which it has revised twice after the local team exceeded its targets. ElevenLabs supports 11 Indian languages, including Hindi, Tamil, Telugu, Gujarati, Malayalam, Assamese and Urdu, and has also expanded coverage across dialects and accents. This broader language support has helped the company unlock enterprise adoption in the country.

VOICE FOR ALL

Enterprises across financial services, telecom, healthcare, SaaS and consumer tech are looking to automate critical workflows, with voice emerging as a key interface. These include Meeesho, Cars24, Mahindra and TVS Motors.

"Usually, an interface makes certain inherent assumptions — a certain amount of literacy and that users are comfortable with touch screens. With this, you exclude a large part of India. Our mission is to make information accessible in all languages, sounds and voices. We build frontier voice models, text-to-speech, speech-to-text, turn-taking, interaction handling, and voice activity detection," Rajaram said.

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thehindu businessline.

QUICKLY.

Sony secures media rights for Asian Games 2026



New Delhi: Sony Pictures Networks India (SPNI) has acquired the media rights for the 20th Asian Games Aichi-Nagoya 2026, slated to take place in Japan from September 19 to October 4, 2026. The Games will be broadcast live on the Sony Sports Network channels and streamed on SonyLIV. OUR BUREAU

Pakistan extends airspace curbs on India till May 24

New Delhi: Pakistan on Tuesday extended the closure of its airspace for Indian planes till May 24 as the curbs will now remain in place for more than a year. In the wake of the terror attack in Kashmir's Pahalgam, which killed 26 people on April 22 last year, India and Pakistan had closed their airspaces for each other. Meanwhile, India has barred Pakistan aircraft from using its airspace till April 24, which is likely to be extended. PTI

Delhi airport gets a boost with T3 Pier C upgrade

MAJOR UPLIFT. Facility awaits regulatory nod; will bolster airport's position as global hub

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The conversion of Pier C at Terminal 3 (T3) of the Indira Gandhi International Airport from domestic to international operations has been completed, sources told *businessline*, adding that the move is aimed at positioning Delhi as a larger global aviation hub amid rising out-bound and transit traffic.

Accordingly, the development comes at a time when Indian airports are witnessing sustained growth in international passenger volumes.

Speaking to *businessline*, sources said the facility, developed by Delhi International Airport Limited (DIAL), is currently awaiting regulatory approvals.

OVERSEAS TRAFFIC

Once operational, the converted pier is expected to significantly augment international passenger handling capacity at Terminal 3, which already manages the bulk of overseas traffic.



BRIDGING GAP. At present, India does not have a designated global hub airport, resulting in a large share of international passengers transiting through hubs in West Asia BLOOMBERG

As per sources, the shift reflects a structural rebalancing of terminal infrastructure in favour of international travel demand, helping airlines add more long-haul routes and improve slot availability as global connectivity from Delhi expands.

It also aligns with broader efforts to enhance the airport's competitiveness among major global transit hubs, sources said.

LESS WAITING

The converted Pier C, sources said, is expected to increase T3's international

passenger handling capacity from around two crore to 3.2 crore passengers annually.

Resultantly, the conversion will ease congestion during peak travel periods amid rising global connectivity and increasing international operations by Indian carriers.

BALANCED USAGE

As part of the transition, domestic operations earlier handled at Pier C were shifted to Terminal 2 (T2) to optimise terminal utilisation and improve passenger flow.

The redistribution of traffic, sources said has been

planned to ensure balanced usage of terminal infrastructure. Last year, DIAL reopened the upgraded T2 to enhance capacity and operational efficiency. The refurbishment was undertaken to accommodate redistributed domestic traffic and streamlined check-in processes.

BETTER UTILISATION

Following the upgrade, airline operations were reallocated, with carriers such as IndiGo and Air India operating a significant number of daily domestic flights from the refurbished terminal, enabling better utilisation of infrastructure.

In addition, sources added that the Pier C conversion is part of a wider strategy to develop Delhi Airport into a hub, integrating domestic and international traffic to facilitate seamless passenger transfers.

At present, India does not have a designated global hub airport, resulting in a large share of outbound international passengers transiting through hubs in West Asia and South-East Asia.

Charter biz remains steady in April, may dip 10-15% from May

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai



TURBULENCE AHEAD. Imposing a disproportionate cost burden on non-scheduled operators will not only impact regional connectivity but also hit emergency operations SRIRAM MA

Air charter demand remained steady in April due to the ongoing elections, but companies expect demand to drop 10-15 per cent from May onwards following an increase in jet fuel prices.

Campaigning for elections in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal is supporting the charter companies, which have seen demand cool off from the leisure segment. Traffic to Dubai, the busiest international destination for Indian charter firms, has been hit too.

REAL IMPACT

According to Club One Air CEO Rajan Mehra, 70-80 per cent of their flights in April are election charters. While the company has not seen a drop in business, the real impact would be seen from next month onwards.

"Corporates are expected to absorb the increased rates but pilgrimage and leisure travel could suffer. On an industry-wide basis, this could result in a 10-15 per cent impact on business," Mehra said.

"Demand has become

more selective. Core users — corporates, high-net-worth individuals, and political movements — continue to rely on charter aviation, but discretionary and first-time demand have cooled off," said Kanika Tekriwal, Founder and CEO of JetSetGo.

BROADER PRESSURE

This is because the cost of operations has increased for charter firms. Fuel cost for a mid-sized jet has risen by ₹75,000-1,25,000 per hour.

Tekriwal said election flying will support aircraft utilisation in the near term but it will not fully offset the broader pressure.

On April 1, state oil marketing companies revised

aviation turbine fuel prices. While the price hike for scheduled domestic flights was limited to 25 per cent, rates for non-scheduled flights were doubled. This impacts not only charter companies but also air ambulance service providers and helicopter operators providing services on pilgrimage routes.

"Prior to March we used to handle 35-40 patients a month within India and that figure remains constant even now. We set up a base in Abu Dhabi in February and from there, on a daily basis, we are transferring one patient to the US or Europe," said Dr Rahul Singh Sardar, Co-founder and Director of IC-ATT air ambulance service.

Glitches in drug licensing portal worry pharma players

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

Pharmaceutical exporters are facing issues in the online national drug licensing system (ONDLS) being implemented for the issue of certificates of pharmaceutical products (COPP) under the World Health Organization's Good Manufacturing Practices (GMP) scheme.

"We have received feedback from a few companies highlighting issues faced during the process," Raja Bhanu, Director General, Pharmaceuticals Export Promotion Council (Pharmexcil), said.

FEEDBACK SOUGHT

In a communication, the Council sought inputs from member-exporters to understand the extent and nature of these challenges across the industry.

To ensure a smooth transition to the ONDLS, Pharmexcil would represent the concerns of the industry to the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO).

It asked exporters to inform it of challenges encountered while applying through ONDLS, technical glitches or system-related problems, and any difficulties in compliance with the new WHO GMP requirements.

THE PORTAL

The ONDLS portal is developed by the Centre for Development of Advanced Computing (CDAC) in co-ordination with the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation, Directorate General of Health Services, Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Government of India, and State/UT Drugs Regulatory Authorities.

SC seeks details on shortcomings in clinical trial rules

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The Supreme Court asked an NGO on Tuesday to file composite documents detailing alleged shortcomings in the 2024 rules that were framed to streamline the approval process for clinical trials of vaccines and new medicines in the country.

A Bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Alok Aradhe was hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) matter filed by NGO Swasthya Adhikar Manch in 2012, alleging largescale clinical drug trials across the country by multinational pharmaceutical firms.

Citing inadequate safety provisions, the PIL alleged that poor citizens were still being used as "guinea pigs" and were not paid adequate compensation.

John Ternus to take over as Apple CEO from Tim Cook

Our Bureau
Mumbai



KEY ROLE. John Ternus, a 25-year Apple veteran, has led hardware engineering across products REUTERS

Apple Inc on Tuesday announced a major leadership transition, naming hardware chief John Ternus as its next Chief Executive Officer, with current CEO Tim Cook set to become Executive Chairman effective September 1, 2026.

The move, unanimously approved by the board, follows what the company described as a long-term succession plan. Cook will remain CEO through the summer to ensure a smooth handover, after which he will take on a strategic role that includes engaging with global policymakers.

INDIA MARKET

"It has been the greatest privilege of my life to be the CEO of Apple," said Cook. During his tenure, Apple's India market grew significantly

with reports of record quarters in recent times.

Commenting on Cook's promotion, Shubham Singh, Research Analyst at Counterpoint Research, said, "India is one of Apple's most vital markets. Cook has done an excellent job of uncovering the country's potential and structurally signalling its global importance through multiple lenses — including the manufacturing push, retail expansion, and the de-

veloper and user communities. Throughout this process, Cook developed a deep personal connection with the Indian audience; John Ternus must now build upon that foundation, especially considering the market's future potential.

Ternus' strong engineering and hardware background, combined with his charismatic personality, is likely to resonate well with India's young and aspirational user base."

Cook himself called Ternus "a visionary" and "without question the right person to lead Apple into the future." Ternus, currently Senior Vice-President of Hardware Engineering, said he was "profoundly grateful" for the opportunity and credited mentorship under Cook and Apple co-founder Steve Jobs.

As part of the transition, long-serving Chairman Arthur Levinson will step down as non-executive Chairman and become lead independent director. Ternus will also join Apple's board.

COOK'S LEGACY

Levinson said Cook's leadership had transformed Apple into "the world's best company", while expressing confidence in Ternus' "deep technical knowledge" and product focus.

Cook, who joined Apple in 1998 and became CEO in 2011, oversaw a dramatic ex-

pansion of the company. During his tenure, Apple's market capitalisation surged from about \$350 billion to \$4 trillion, while annual revenue nearly quadrupled to over \$416 billion in fiscal 2025. The company also broadened its global footprint to more than 200 countries and built an installed base exceeding 2.5 billion devices.

Ternus, a 25-year Apple veteran, has led hardware engineering across flagship products including iPhone, Mac and iPad. As part of the company's product design team since 2001, he played a key role in developing newer offerings such as the MacBook Neo and the latest iPhone lineup, and has driven advances in durability, materials and environmental design. The leadership shift marks one of the most significant transitions at Apple since Cook succeeded Jobs in 2011.

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